Foundations

How to sit, shape your hands, and find your way around the keys.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Welcome to the piano
2. Sitting at the piano
3. Hand shape and finger numbers
4. The map of the keyboard
5. Finding C and Middle C
6. The musical alphabet
7. The Doxology
8. Jesus Loves Me

1. Welcome to the piano

How this app works, and your very first note.

Hello, pianist

Every great pianist started exactly where you are now. These lessons go one small step at a time, from how to sit all the way to real classical pieces.

Each lesson mixes three things: a short read, a picture, and practice on your piano. When it's time to play, this app **listens through your phone's microphone** and waits until it hears the right note. There's no timer and no rush.

Stand your phone on the music stand, sideways, and turn the volume up a little so you can hear the examples.

Turning on listening

Tap the **microphone button** at the top right. Your phone will ask for permission the first time. Allow it.

When listening is on, the little meter next to it moves when you play. If you don't have a piano handy, you can always tap the keys on screen instead.

Tip: practice in a quiet room. A TV or conversation in the background can confuse the listening.

Practise · Play any white key

Press any white key on your piano, firmly and clearly. Watch the screen light up when it hears you.

2. Sitting at the piano

Bench height, distance, and a relaxed body.

Your seat

Good posture makes everything easier and prevents aches.

- Sit on the **front half** of the bench, facing the middle of the keyboard.
- Your **elbows** should be about level with the keys. Raise or lower the bench, or use a cushion.
- Sit far enough back that your elbows are slightly in front of your body when your hands are on the keys.
- **Feet flat** on the floor (or on a box if they don't reach).

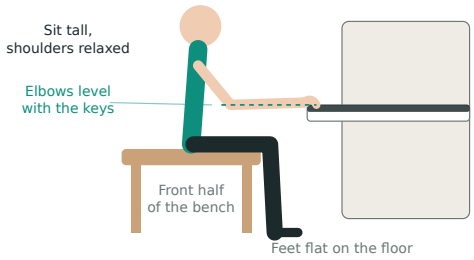


Figure 1.1 · Your seat

Stay loose

Tension is the enemy of good playing. Before every practice session, try this:

1. Roll your shoulders back and let them drop.
2. Let your arms hang by your sides and shake out your hands.
3. Take one slow breath, then lift your hands to the keys.

If anything starts to hurt while you play, stop and shake out again. Short, relaxed practice beats long, tense practice.

> **Review**
>
> Where should you sit on the bench?
>
> **Answer:** On the front half The front half lets your feet stay grounded and your arms move freely.

> **Review**
>
> Your elbows should be…
>
> **Answer:** About level with the keys Level elbows let your forearms rest naturally, with no reaching up or down.

3. Hand shape and finger numbers

The "bubble" hand, and naming fingers 1 to 5.

The bubble hand

Let your hand hang by your side. Notice how the fingers curve naturally? That's the shape you want at the piano.

Imagine holding a **bubble** under your palm. Fingers are curved, you play on the **tips** (not the flat pads), and your wrist stays level, neither drooping nor high.

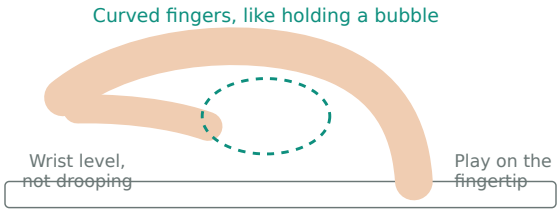


Figure 1.2 · The bubble hand

Finger numbers

Piano music numbers your fingers so it can tell you which one to use. On **both hands**, the thumb is **1** and the pinky is **5**.

Try it now: hold up both hands and wiggle finger 3 (middle) on each. Then 1, then 5, then 2, then 4.

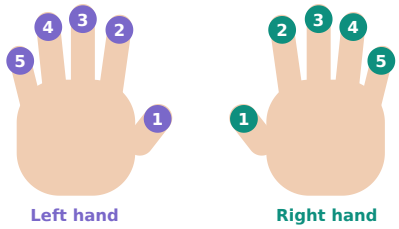


Figure 1.3 · Finger numbers

> **Review**
>
> Which finger is number 1?
>
> **Answer:** Thumb The thumb is always 1, on both hands.

> **Review**
>
> Which finger is number 4?
>
> **Answer:** Ring finger Count from the thumb: 1 thumb, 2 index, 3 middle, 4 ring, 5 pinky.

Finger warm-up

Rest your right hand on a table in the bubble shape. Tap each finger in turn: **1 2 3 4 5**, then back **5 4 3 2 1**. Keep the other fingers relaxed and touching the table.

Now do the same with your left hand. Fingers 4 and 5 feel weak at first. That's normal and gets better quickly.

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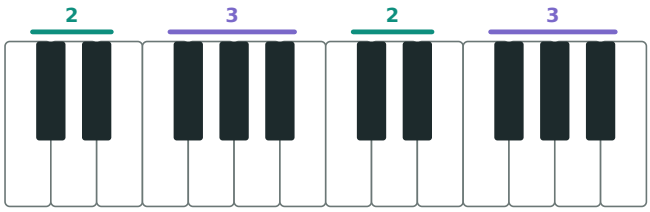
4. The map of the keyboard

Black keys come in groups of two and three.

Twos and threes

A piano can look like a sea of identical keys, but there's a simple pattern. The **black keys** come in groups of **two** and **three**, over and over, all the way up.

These groups are your map. You'll find every note by looking at where it sits next to them.
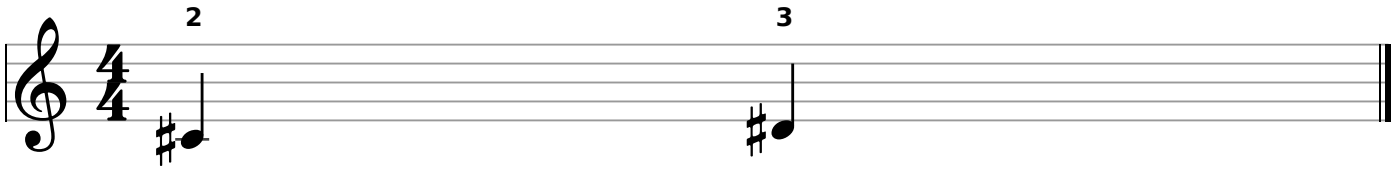


Black keys repeat: a group of 2, then a group of 3

Figure 1.4 · Twos and threes

Practise · A group of two

Find a group of TWO black keys near the middle of your piano and play both, one after the other.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A group of three

Now find the group of THREE black keys just to the right, and play all three, left to right.

Low and high

Play a few keys at the far left of your piano, then the far right. Left is **low** (deep, rumbly sounds). Right is **high** (bright, tinkly sounds).

Moving right is called moving **up**. Moving left is moving **down**.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which note is higher, the first or the second?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** The second The second note was further to the right, so it sounds higher.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen again. Which is higher this time?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** The first The first note was higher. Training your ear like this helps you catch your own mistakes.

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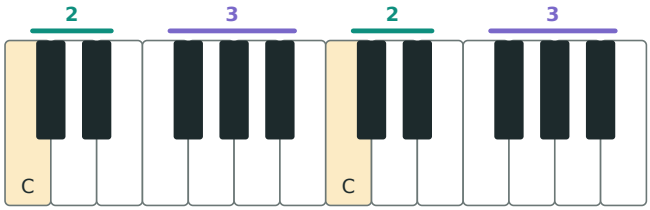
5. Finding C and Middle C

Your home base on the keyboard.

C lives left of the two

The white key just **to the left of every group of two black keys** is called **C**.

There are several Cs on your piano, one for every group of two.

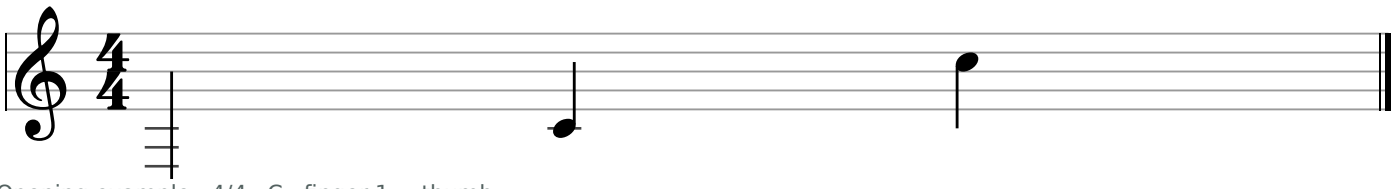


Every C sits just left of a group of two black keys

Figure 1.5 · C lives left of the two

Practise · Play some Cs

Play three Cs: one low, one in the middle, one higher. Any order is fine.

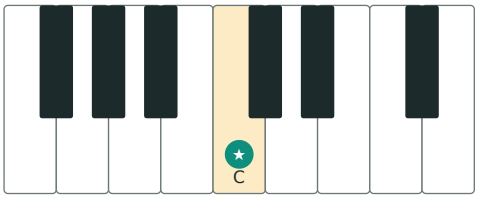


Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Middle C

The C closest to the middle of your piano (usually right in front of you, often under the brand name) is called **Middle C**. Musicians also call it **C4**.

Middle C is home base. Almost every beginner piece starts near it.



Middle C is the C nearest the center of the piano

Figure 1.6 · Middle C

Practise · Play Middle C

Play Middle C with your right thumb (finger 1), four times.

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6. The musical alphabet

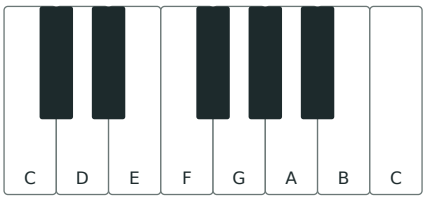
Seven letters, A to G, then repeat.

Only seven letters

Music uses just seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. After G, it starts again at A.

Starting from C, the white keys go **C D E F G A B**, then the next C. The black keys get their names later.

Tip: **D** sits in the middle of the two black keys, and **F** is just left of the three.

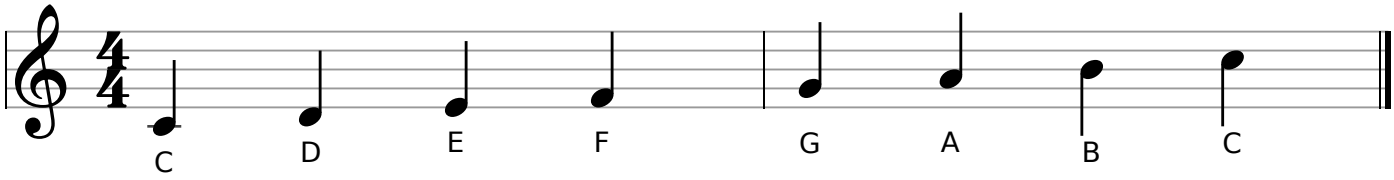


C D E F G A B, then C again

Figure 1.7 · Only seven letters

Practise · Walk up from Middle C

Starting on Middle C, play every white key going up until you reach the next C. Say each letter out loud as you play.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · And back down

Now walk back down from C to Middle C, naming each note.

> **Review**
>
> What letter comes after G?
>
> **Answer:** A After G the alphabet starts again at A.

> **Review**
>
> Which white key sits between the two black keys?
>
> **Answer:** D D is "in the doghouse" between the two black keys.

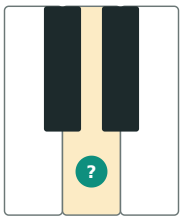


Figure 1.8 · Lesson illustration

Practise · Find the notes

Labels are off now. Find these notes near Middle C: D, then F, then A. Use the black keys as your map.

7. The Doxology

Your first piece: the opening of a 450-year-old hymn tune.

Your first recital

Every unit ends with a **recital**: a piece to practice and then perform from start to finish, with no hints from the keyboard.

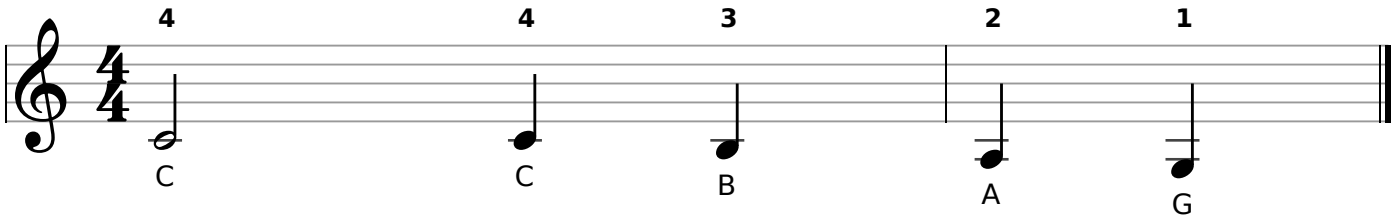
Your first piece is the opening line of the **Doxology** ("Praise God, from whom all blessings flow"). Its tune, called **Old Hundredth**, was published in Geneva in 1551 and has been sung ever since.

The first half walks **down** the white keys from Middle C: C C B A G. Then your thumb hops back to Middle C and walks **up**: C D E.

This is the start of a longer journey: each unit adds a little more of the Doxology, until you can play the whole hymn with both hands.

Practise · Walking down

Put finger 4 on Middle C. Walk down: C C B A G, ending on your thumb.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Walking up

Move your thumb to Middle C and walk up: C D E. Hold the last note.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole line, with hints. Tap Listen to hear how it should sound.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

8. Jesus Loves Me

A gentle children's hymn that climbs a little higher.

Jesus Loves Me

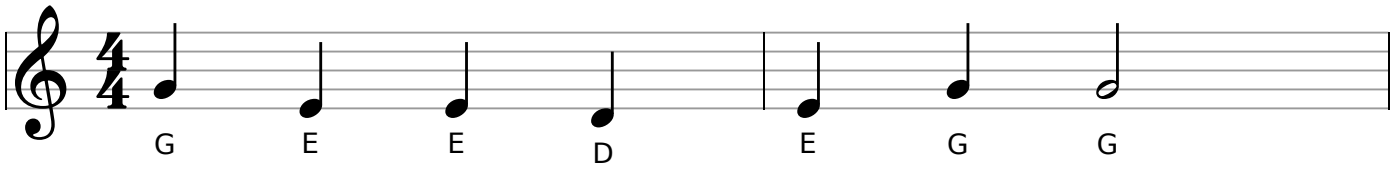
Anna Bartlett Warner wrote these words in 1860, and William **Bradbury** gave them their tune two years later. It has been sung by children all over the world ever since.

The verse starts on **G** and leans down to E: "G E E D E G G". Then it reaches up to **A** and the high **C**.

Your hand will need to move a little. Follow the note names on the keys, and don't worry about which finger plays which note yet.

Practise · Verse, first half

"Jesus loves me, this I know, for the Bible tells me so."



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Verse, second half

"Little ones to Him belong; they are weak, but He is strong." It ends back on Middle C.

Practise · The chorus

"Yes, Jesus loves me…" Hold the long notes for their full count.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

Verse and chorus together, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- [ ] Set up the bench and relax my shoulders, wrists, and hands.
- [ ] Name fingers 1 to 5 on both hands.
- [ ] Use groups of two and three black keys to find C and Middle C.
- [ ] Name the white keys and recognize whether notes move higher or lower.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?

First steps

Five-finger positions, steady beats, and your first real tunes.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Right hand C position
2. Left hand C position
3. Steady beats
4. Steps and skips
5. First tune: Hot Cross Buns
6. Lightly Row
7. Mary Had a Little Lamb
8. Doxology: the second line
9. Sleep, Baby, Sleep
10. Left hand tune: Au Clair de la Lune
11. Ode to Joy (right hand)
12. All My Little Ducklings
13. Hands together
14. Au Clair de la Lune, hands together
15. Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee
16. When the Saints Go Marching In

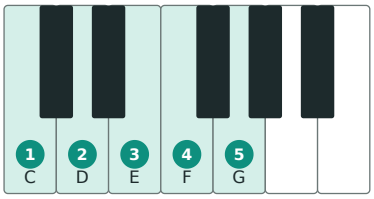
1. Right hand C position

One finger per key, thumb on Middle C.

Five fingers, five keys

Put your right thumb (1) on **Middle C**. Let the other fingers rest on the next white keys: 2 on D, 3 on E, 4 on F, 5 on G.

This is the **C position**. Each finger has its own key, so you never have to look for notes. Keep that bubble shape!

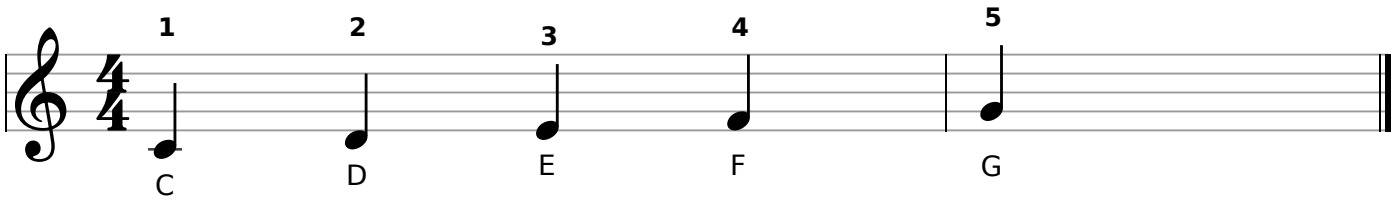


Right hand C position: thumb on Middle C

Figure 2.1 · Five fingers, five keys

Practise · Up the C position

Play C D E F G with fingers 1 2 3 4 5. Slow and even, like footsteps.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · And back down

Now come back down: G F E D C, fingers 5 4 3 2 1.

Practise · Up and down together

Put it together without stopping. Listen for every note sounding equally loud.

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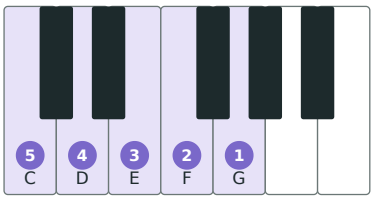
2. Left hand C position

The mirror image: pinky on C.

The left hand

Your left hand is a mirror image. Place your **left pinky (5)** on the C **below** Middle C. Then 4 on D, 3 on E, 2 on F and thumb (1) on G.

So going up the keys, the left hand counts **5 4 3 2 1**. That feels strange at first. Go slowly.

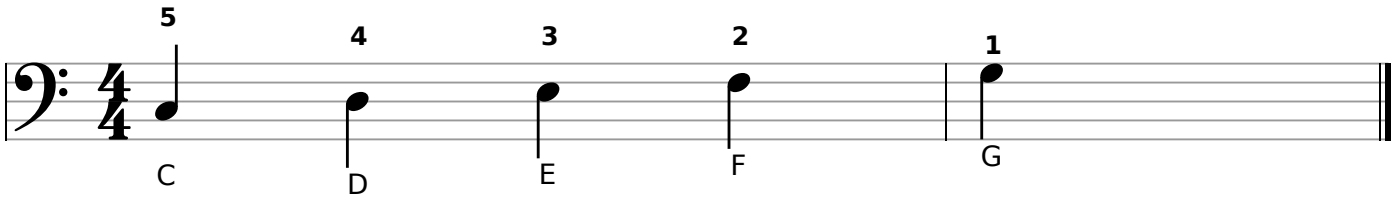


t hand C position: pinky on the C below Middl

Figure 2.2 · The left hand

Practise · Left hand up

Play C D E F G with left-hand fingers 5 4 3 2 1.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand down

And back down, fingers 1 2 3 4 5.

Practise · Pinky and thumb

Bounce between your outside fingers: C and G, then the middle, E.

---

3. Steady beats

Quarter, half and whole notes.

Music has a pulse

Under all music there's a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat or a clock ticking. Notes last for a number of beats:

- **Quarter note**: 1 beat
- **Half note**: 2 beats
- **Whole note**: 4 beats

In this app, longer notes show as wider boxes. Count out loud: "one, two, three, four".

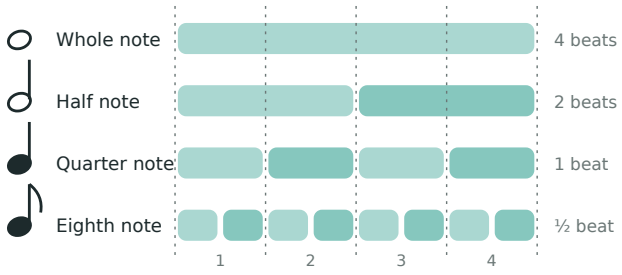
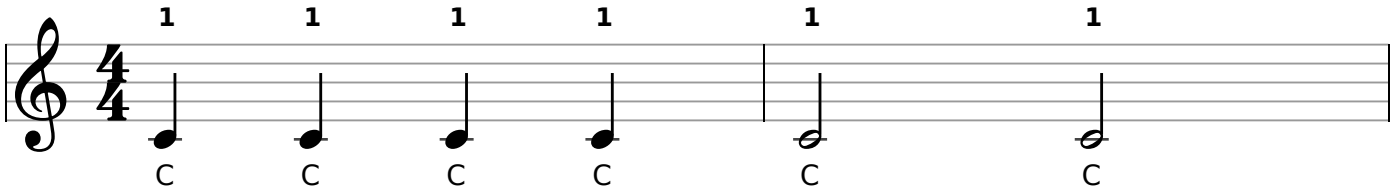


Figure 2.3 · Music has a pulse

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. How many beats does each note last?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** 2 beats Those were half notes: two beats each.

Practise · Counting while you play

Tap "Listen" first to hear the rhythm, then play it on Middle C, counting out loud.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Mixing lengths

Hold the wide notes longer. Count "1 2 3 4" in every group.

---

4. Steps and skips

How notes move: next door, or jumping over one.

Moving by step or skip

When a melody moves to the very next key, that's a **step** (like C to D). When it jumps over one key, that's a **skip** (like C to E).

In C position, a step uses the next finger, and a skip skips a finger.

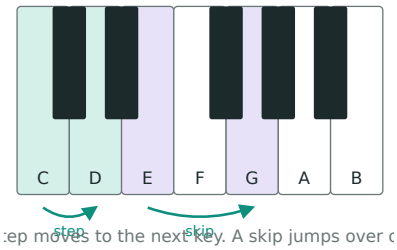
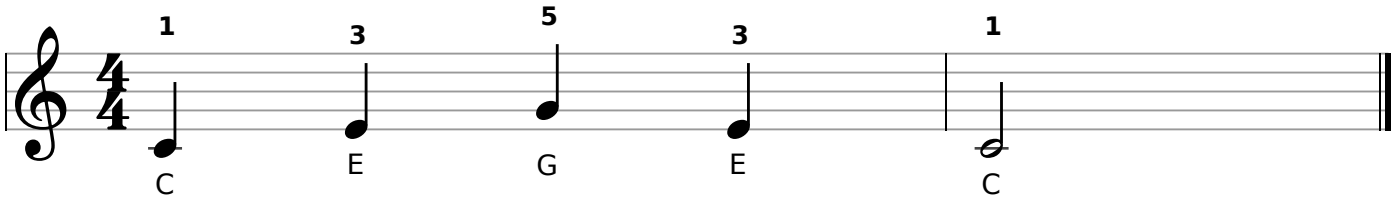


Figure 2.4 · Moving by step or skip

Practise · Skipping up

Play C, E, G with fingers 1, 3, 5, then back down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Did the melody move by steps or by skips?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Steps C, D, E, F: each note is next door to the last.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Skips C, E, G: every note skipped over one.

Practise · Steps and skips mixed

Watch the fingers: some steps, some skips.

---

5. First tune: Hot Cross Buns

Three notes, one happy song.

Your first song

This old street-seller's song uses just three notes: **E D C**, played with fingers 3 2 1. The fast notes in the middle are **eighth notes**, two per beat.

Tap **Listen** to hear it first. Then play along at your own speed.

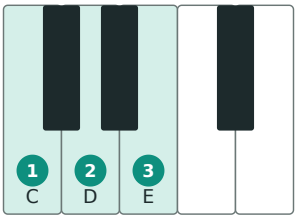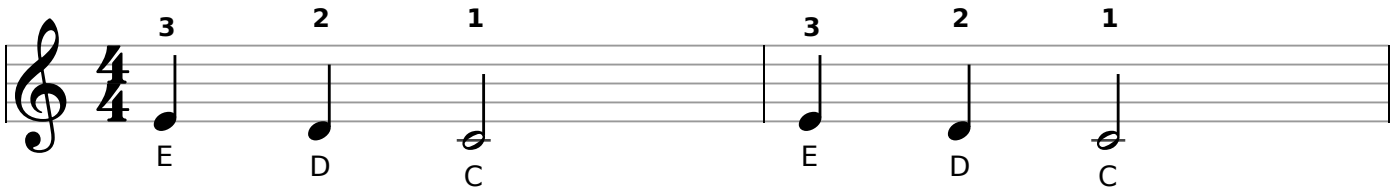


Figure 2.5 · Your first song

Practise · Hot Cross Buns

Right hand in C position. Go slowly. The app waits for you.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

6. Lightly Row

A rowing song that walks up and down C position.

Lightly Row

This German children's song is called **Hänschen klein** at home, and **Lightly Row** in English. It fits your C position exactly: thumb on Middle C, finger 5 on G.

Each line starts with a skip down from G to E, then a step down to D and C. Listen for the pattern and it will play itself.

Practise · First verse

Thumb on Middle C. G, E, E; F, D, D; then walk up C D E F G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lightly Row

The whole song. The middle part repeats D, then E, then climbs to G.

7. Mary Had a Little Lamb

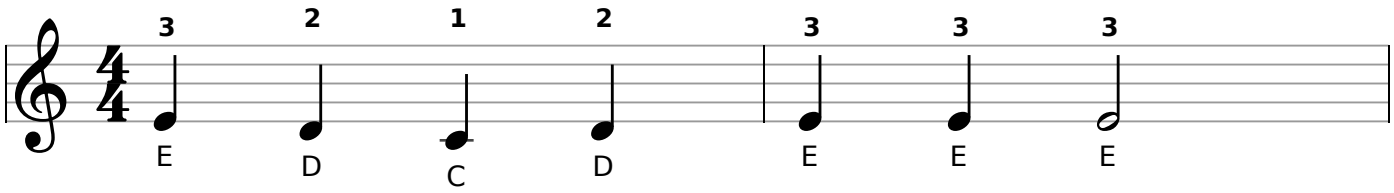
Four fingers and a skip up to G.

A longer tune

This melody uses **C D E** plus a skip up to **G** with your pinky. Keep your hand in C position the whole time and the notes are always under your fingers.

Practise · Mary Had a Little Lamb

Play the whole tune. Notice the long note at the end: hold it for four beats.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

8. Doxology: the second line

Add "Praise Him, all creatures here below" to the line you know.

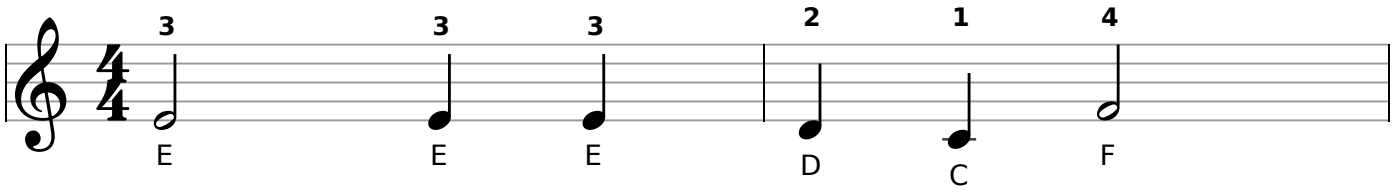
The Doxology grows

Your first recital was the opening line of the **Doxology**. In every unit from now on you'll add a little more, until you can play the whole hymn with both hands.

Line two, **"Praise Him, all creatures here below"**, starts on E with three in a row, steps down to C, then jumps up to F and steps back down.

Practise · Line 2

Thumb on Middle C, so finger 3 is on E. Three Es, then D, C, a little jump to F, and back down E, D.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

Start with finger 4 on Middle C as before. After "flow", move your hand so your thumb is on C again for line two.

9. Sleep, Baby, Sleep

A gentle German lullaby in C position.

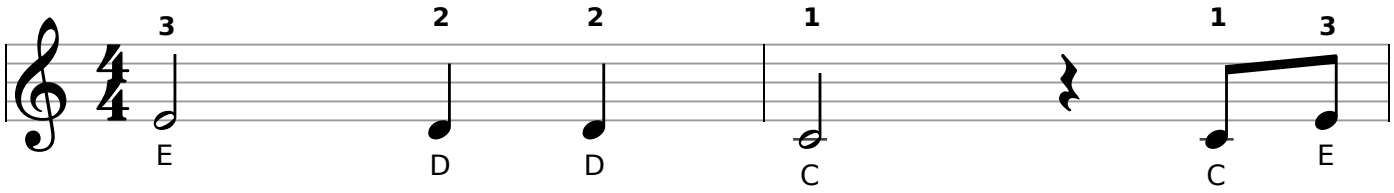
A lullaby

Schlaf, Kindlein, schlaf ("Sleep, baby, sleep") is a German lullaby that has been sung for over 200 years. Play it softly and slowly, as if someone is falling asleep.

Look out for the **two quick notes** after the first rest: C and E, twice as fast as a quarter note, leading into the high G.

Practise · Sleep, Baby, Sleep

Thumb on Middle C. Softly. Count the rests: they are part of the music.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

---

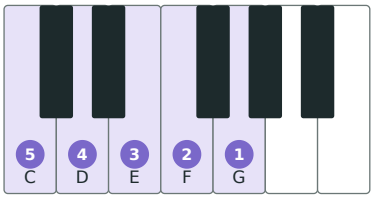
10. Left hand tune: Au Clair de la Lune

A French folk song for your left hand.

Left hand leads

Melodies aren't only for the right hand. Place your left hand in C position (pinky on the C below Middle C) and play this gentle French song.

Remember: on the left hand, C is finger **5**, D is **4**, E is **3**.

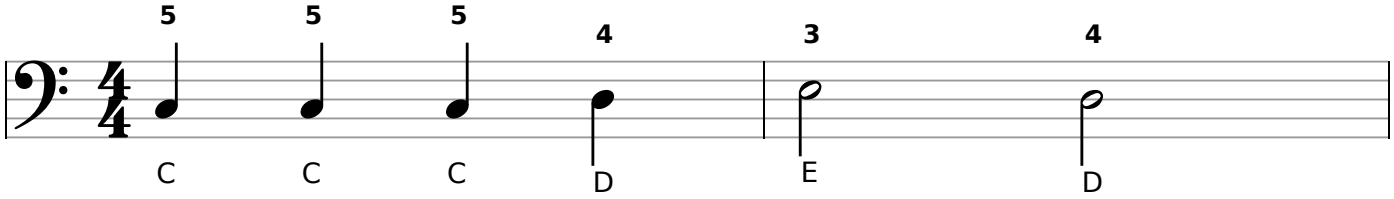


t hand C position: pinky on the C below Middl

Figure 2.6 · Left hand leads

Practise · Au Clair de la Lune

Left hand only. Let it sing, softly and smoothly.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

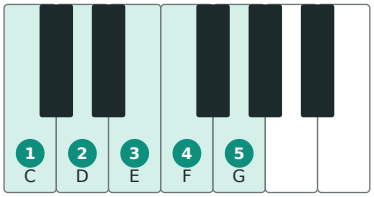
11. Ode to Joy (right hand)

Beethoven's famous melody, in C position.

Beethoven!

This melody is from Beethoven's **Ninth Symphony** (1824), one of the most famous pieces ever written. And it fits perfectly in your right-hand C position.

It has two halves that are almost the same. Only the ending is different. Watch for the **dotted** note near the end of each half: it lasts a beat and a half.
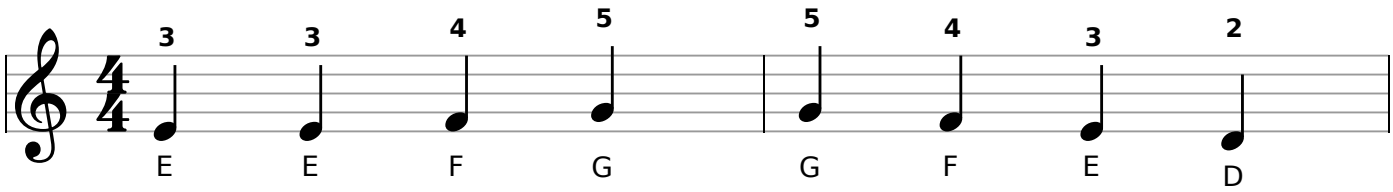


Right hand C position: thumb on Middle C

Figure 2.7 · Beethoven!

Practise · First half

Play the first half. Fingers on C D E F G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Second half

Same start, but this time it ends on C, home.

Practise · The whole melody

Both halves without stopping. You are playing Beethoven!

12. All My Little Ducklings

A German children's song that stretches up to A.

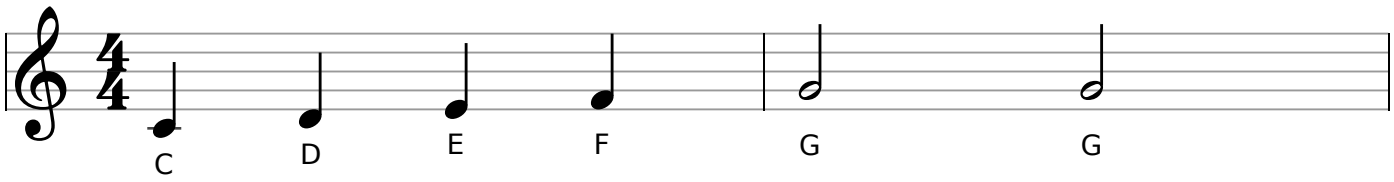
Alle meine Entchen

Every German child learns **Alle meine Entchen**: "All my little ducklings swimming on the lake, heads down in the water, tails up in the air."

It walks up C D E F G, then needs one note beyond C position: **A**. Let your hand spread a little so finger 5 reaches A. Then it walks back down to Middle C.

Practise · All My Little Ducklings

Up C D E F G G, then the As, then step down: F, E, D, C.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

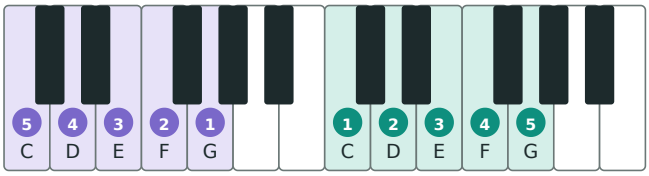
13. Hands together

Both hands at once, starting simple.

Two hands, one brain

Playing with both hands is the big step that makes the piano sound like a piano. Start with both hands in C position, an octave (eight notes) apart.

When both hands play the **same letters** together, your left hand uses 5 4 3 2 1 while your right uses 1 2 3 4 5. Go very slowly; the app waits until it hears both notes.

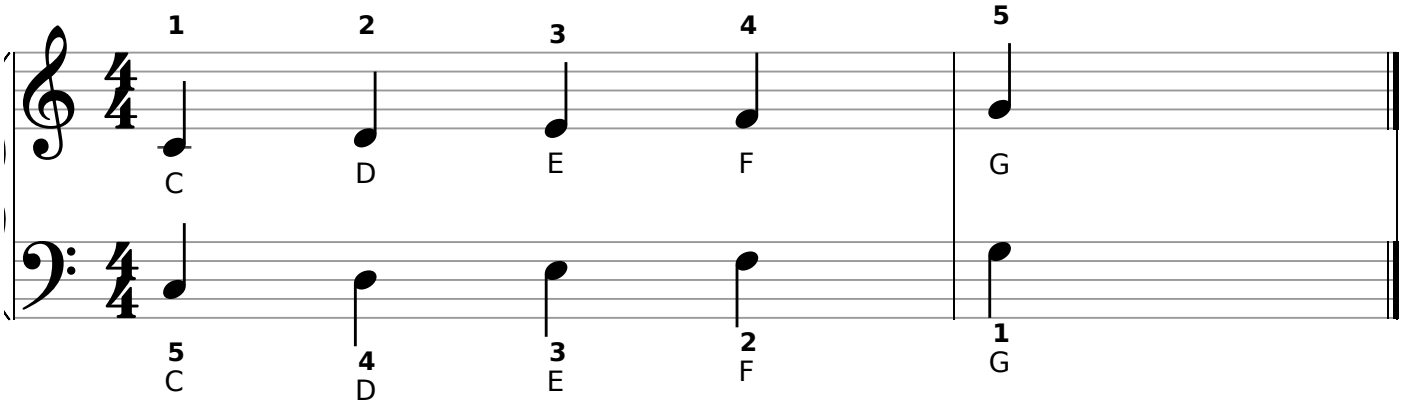


Both hands in C position

Figure 2.8 · Two hands, one brain

Practise · Both hands up

Play C with both hands together (left 5, right 1), then D, E, F, G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Both hands down

And back down together.

Melody and bass

Usually the right hand plays the **melody** while the left hand plays slower, lower **bass** notes underneath.

Next you'll play Ode to Joy with a single left-hand note at the start of each group of four beats: just C or G. Hold the left note while the right hand keeps going.

Practise · Ode to Joy, hands together

Left hand plays C (finger 5) or G (finger 1) and holds it. Right hand plays the melody.

---

14. Au Clair de la Lune, hands together

The French tune in your right hand, with a left-hand bass.

Melody and bass

You played **Au Clair de la Lune** with your left hand. Now the right hand takes the tune, and the left hand plays long low notes underneath: **C** with finger 5 and **G** with your thumb.

The left hand only moves on beats 1 and 3. Play the tune twice: the second time, the words are "prête-moi ta plume".

Practise · Left hand alone

Pinky on the C below Middle C. C, then C and G, C and G, and C.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Au Clair de la Lune, hands together

Both hands. The left hand holds its notes while the right hand sings.

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15. Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee

The hymn set to Beethoven's Ode to Joy, with both hands.

A hymn from Beethoven

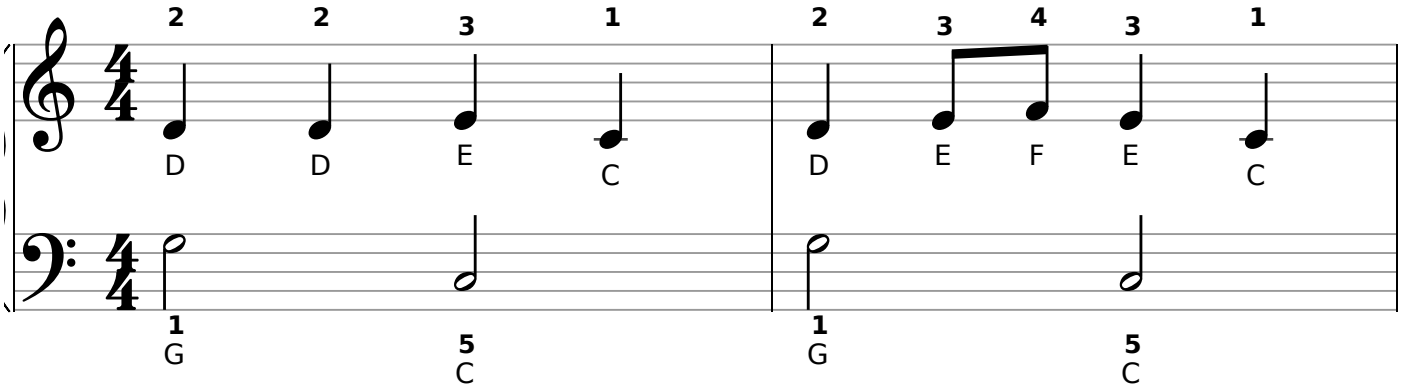
In 1907 Henry van Dyke wrote the words **"Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee"** to fit Beethoven's Ode to Joy melody. It's now one of the best-loved hymns in the world.

The hymn has four lines. You already know three of them! The new one is the **third line**, which bounces between D and E and has quick eighth notes.

At the end of that line the melody dips to a low G. Your **left-hand thumb** plays it, since it's sitting right there.

Practise · The new middle line

Right hand. Watch the quick F between the Es. The left thumb plays the final low G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Dress rehearsal

All four lines, both hands, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

---

16. When the Saints Go Marching In

A lively spiritual in C position, with rests to count.

When the Saints Go Marching In

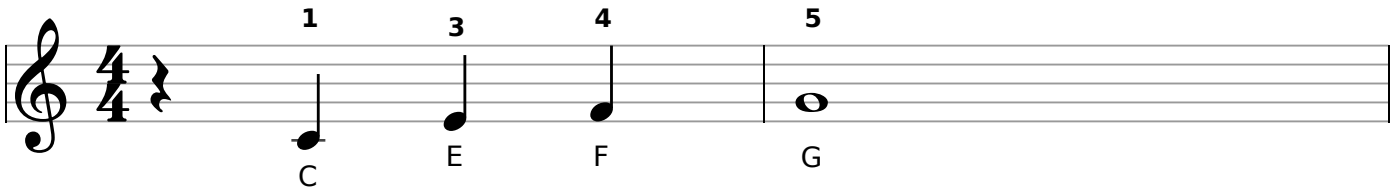
This African-American spiritual became the anthem of **New Orleans** jazz bands. It's bright, bouncy and fun to play.

It sits entirely in **C position**: thumb on Middle C, one finger per key up to G.

Most lines start with a **rest**: a silent beat. Count "1" in your head, then play on "2 3 4". The long notes are **whole notes**: hold them for four beats.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"Oh when the saints go marching in…" Rest on beat 1, then C E F and a long G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

"Oh Lord, I want to be in that number…" and home to C.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole song, with hints. Keep the beat steady through the rests.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Find C position with either hand without labelled keys.
- ☐ Keep a steady beat while playing steps and skips.
- ☐ Play a familiar melody with the suggested fingers.
- ☐ Practise each hand separately, then bring both hands together slowly.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?

Reading music

The staff, both clefs, note lengths, rests and time signatures.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. The staff and the treble clef
2. Reading without names
3. The bass clef
4. The grand staff
5. Counting and bar lines
6. Doxology: the whole melody
7. When I Survey the Wondrous Cross
8. Eighth notes: "1 and 2 and"
9. Ties and pickup notes
0. Rests and 3/4 time
11. Kum Ba Yah
12. Dotted rhythms: Largo
13. Muss i denn
14. Repeat signs
15. Fox, You Stole the Goose
16. Reading hands together
17. Intervals: 2nds to 5ths
18. Amazing Grace
19. Simple Gifts
20. Away in a Manger

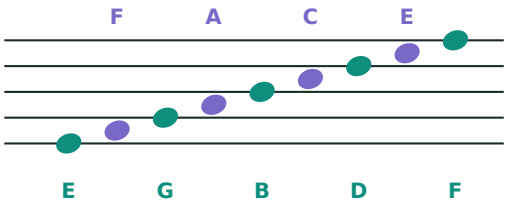
1. The staff and the treble clef

Five lines that show how high a note is.

Five lines

Written music sits on a **staff**: five lines with four spaces between them. Notes are written **on** a line or **in** a space. The higher on the staff, the higher the note.

The curly sign at the start of the staff is the **treble clef** (you'll see it on the next page). It's used for higher notes, usually the right hand. A handy saying for the lines, bottom to top: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**oes **F**ine. The spaces spell **F A C E**.



Lines: Every Good Boy Does Fine
Spaces: F A C E

Figure 3.1 · Five lines

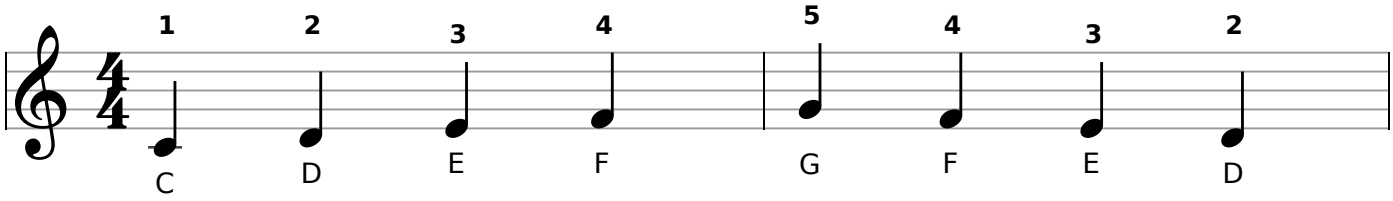
Middle C on the staff

Middle C sits **below** the treble staff on its own short line, called a **ledger line**. Then D hangs just under the staff, E sits on the bottom line, F in the first space, G on the second line.

Notice how each note moves up one notch: line, space, line, space. Steps on the keyboard are steps on the staff.

Practise · Play what you see

Read the notes on the staff and play them. The names are shown underneath to help.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** E The bottom line of the treble staff is E: "Every".

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** G The second line is G: "Good". The treble clef curls around this line, which is why it's also called the G clef.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** Middle C A note on its own little line just below the staff is Middle C.

---

2. Reading without names

Train your eyes to read C to G.

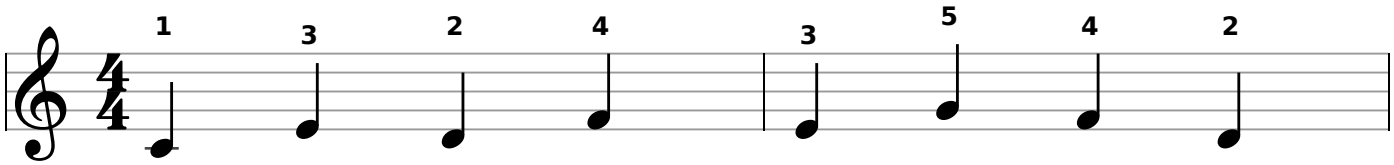
Read by shape

Good readers don't name every note. They look at the **direction** and the **distance**: up or down, a step or a skip.

Line to the next space is a step. Line to the next line is a skip. Watch for these shapes as you play.

Practise · Reading drill 1

No names this time. Read from the staff. The keyboard still shows where to go if you get stuck.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Reading drill 2

This time the keyboard won't show you. Read the staff. Tap "Show me" if you need a hint.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** F F is in the first space: the F of "FACE".

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** D D hangs just below the bottom line.

3. The bass clef

Low notes, usually for the left hand.

The bass clef

Low notes use the **bass clef**, which looks like a backwards C with two dots (shown on the next page). Its two dots surround the line for **F**, so it's also called the F clef.

Lines, bottom to top: **G**ood **B**oys **D**o **F**ine **A**lways. Spaces: **A**ll **C**ows **E**at **G**rass.

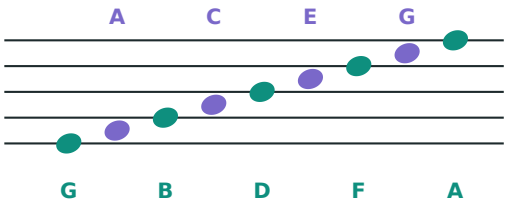


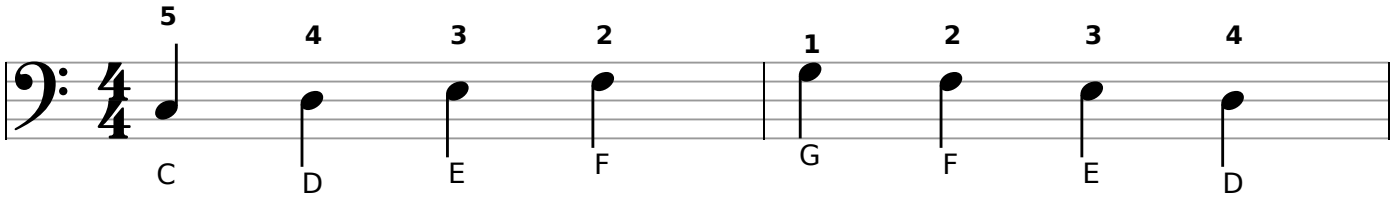
Figure 3.2 · The bass clef

Left hand C position on the staff

The C your left pinky sits on is in the **second space** of the bass staff. From there, D is on the middle line, E in the next space, F on the fourth line and G in the top space.

Practise · Read with your left hand

Left hand in C position. Read the bass staff.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass reading drill

No names now. Up or down? Step or skip?

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** C C is the second space of the bass staff: "All Cows".

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** F F is the fourth line, right between the two dots of the bass clef.

4. The grand staff

Both clefs joined, with Middle C in between.

Two staves together

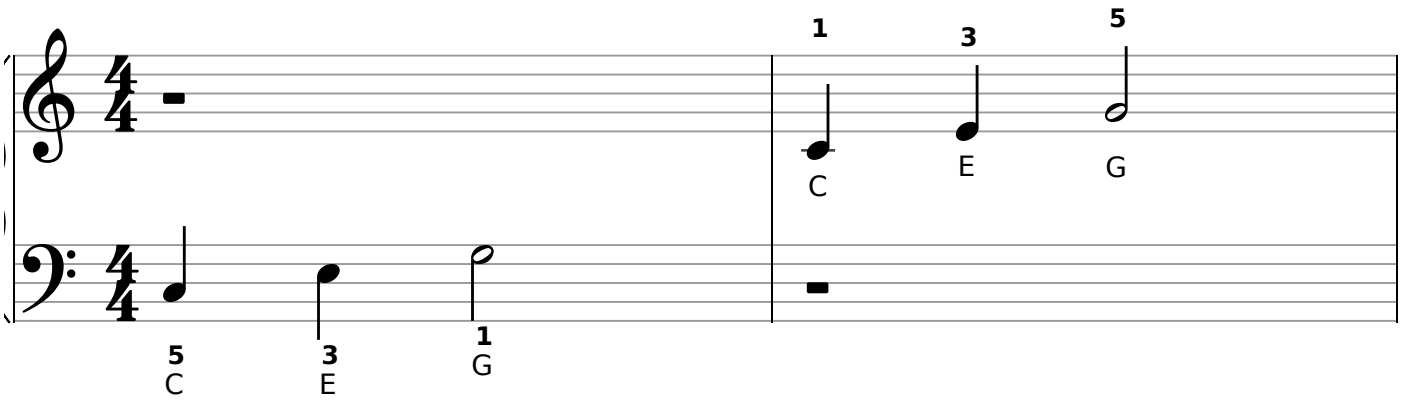
Piano music joins a treble staff and a bass staff with a brace. This is the **grand staff**. The top is usually your right hand, the bottom your left.

Middle C sits right between them. It can be written just below the treble staff or just above the bass staff. Same key, same sound.

> **Review**
>
> On the grand staff, which hand usually reads the bottom staff?
>
> **Answer:** Left hand The bass (bottom) staff is usually for the left hand.

Practise · Taking turns

The hands take turns: left hand first, then right. Read each staff.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

5. Counting and bar lines

Measures, time signatures, and Twinkle Twinkle.

Bars and time signatures

Music is divided into small boxes called **bars** (or measures) by vertical **bar lines**.

The two numbers at the start are the **time signature**. The top number tells you how many beats are in each bar. **4/4** means four beats per bar: count "1 2 3 4, 1 2 3 4".

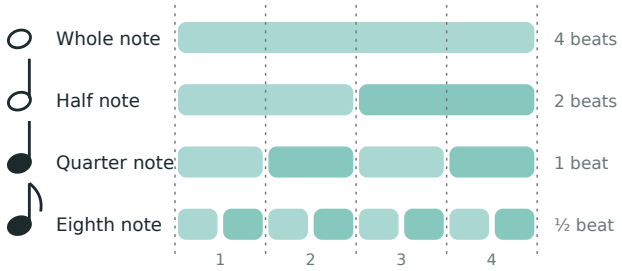


Figure 3.3 · Bars and time signatures

> **Review**
>
> In 4/4 time, how many beats are in each bar?
>
> **Answer:** 4 The top number of the time signature is the number of beats per bar.

> **Review**
>
> How many quarter notes fit into one half note?
>
> **Answer:** 2 A half note is 2 beats, a quarter note is 1 beat.

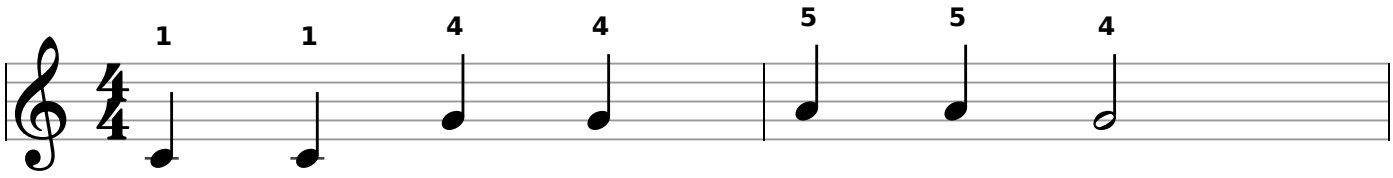
Twinkle, Twinkle

Mozart wrote a famous set of variations on this melody. It needs one note beyond C position: **A**. Here's the trick: put your thumb on C, then let your fingers spread so that **4 lands on G and 5 on A**.

Later in the song your thumb moves to D. Read the finger numbers on the keyboard.

Practise · Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star

Count 1 2 3 4 in every bar. Hold the half notes for two beats.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

6. Doxology: the whole melody

All four lines, read from the staff and counted in 4.

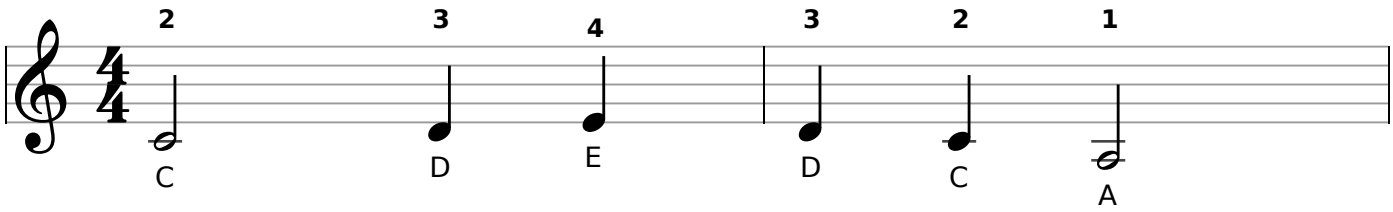
Four lines, twelve bars

Now you can read the staff and count bars, so here is the **whole Doxology melody**. Every line is three bars long, and every line has the same rhythm: a half note, four quarters, then three half notes.

Count it: **1-2 3 4 | 1 2 3-4 | 1-2 3-4**.

Practise · Line 3

"Praise Him above": start with finger 2 on Middle C. When the tune dips to the low A, play it with your thumb, then walk back up B, C.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 4

The last line starts high: thumb on Middle C and finger 5 on G. It skips down G, E, C, then climbs back and walks home to C.

Practise · The whole melody

All four lines, reading from the staff. Count steadily, and hold each half note for its full two beats.

7. When I Survey the Wondrous Cross

Isaac Watts's hymn, counted in 4.

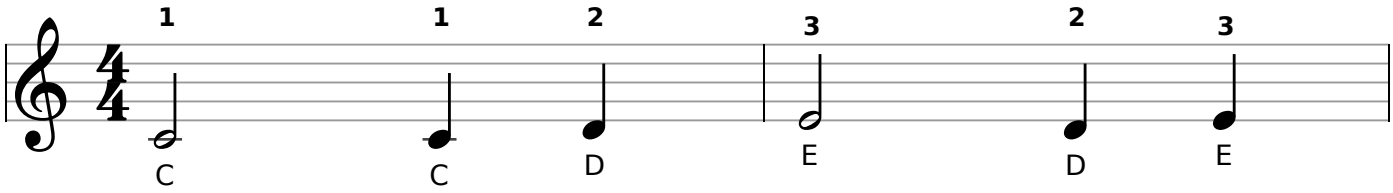
A hymn to count

Isaac Watts wrote these words in 1707, and Lowell Mason's tune **Hamburg** (1824) is how most churches sing them. It's slow and steady: perfect for counting.

Most bars are a half note and two quarters, or a whole note at the end of a line: count **1-2 3 4**, or **1-2-3-4**. Line two dips to the **B** below Middle C: reach your thumb down for it, then come back.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

Thumb on Middle C. Count out loud: 1-2, 3, 4.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · When I Survey the Wondrous Cross

All four lines. Hold every whole note for its full four beats.

---

8. Eighth notes: "1 and 2 and"

Two quick notes in one beat.

Half a beat

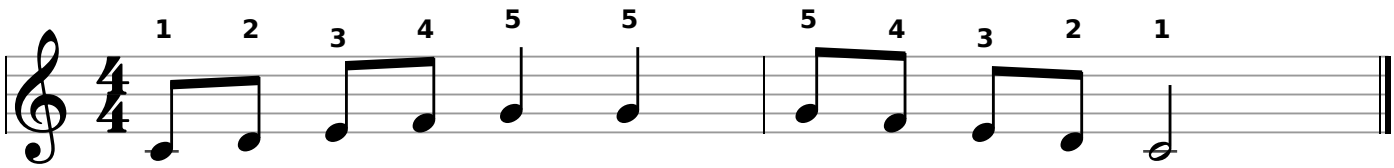
An **eighth note** lasts half a beat, so two of them fit into one beat. On their own they have a little flag. In pairs they're joined by a thick line called a **beam**.

To count them, put the word "and" between the beats: "**1** and **2** and **3** and **4** and". The numbers land on the beat and the "ands" land halfway between.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which half has the quicker notes?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** The second half The second half has eighth notes: two notes in every beat, so they move twice as fast.

Practise · Running eighths

Count out loud: "1 and 2 and". The eighth notes go up and down the C position.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hot Cross Buns, with eighths

"One a penny, two a penny" is all eighth notes. Keep them even.

9. Ties and pickup notes

Holding across a bar line, and songs that start early.

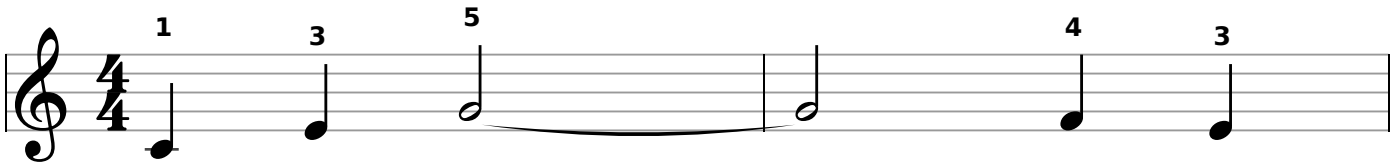
The tie

A **tie** is a curved line joining two notes of the **same pitch**. Play the first note and keep holding it through the second. Don't play it again.

Ties let a note last across a bar line, like the G above: two beats in the first bar plus two more in the next.

Practise · Hold through the tie

Play each tied note once and keep it held while you count. The app moves on by itself.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Pickup notes

Some songs start **before** beat 1. Those first few notes are called a **pickup**, and they sit in a short bar of their own at the very start.

"Happy Birthday" is a perfect example. You sing "Hap-py" first, and the strong beat lands on "**birth**". It's in 3/4 time, so count "3 | **1** 2 3".

Practise · Happy Birthday

Start on the pickup ("Hap-py"), then lean into beat 1 on "birth". Thumb on Middle C.

10. Rests and 3/4 time

Silence counts too, and the waltz feel.

Rests

A **rest** is a written silence. It lasts just as long as the note it matches: a quarter rest is one beat of silence, a half rest is two.

Keep counting through rests! Lift your finger, but keep your hand ready. When the app reaches a rest, it simply moves on.

Three beats: the waltz

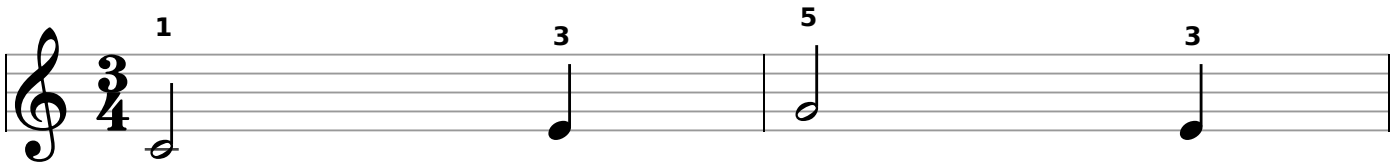
In **3/4** time each bar has **three beats**: "**1** 2 3, **1** 2 3". The first beat is a little stronger. This is the rhythm of a waltz.

A **dotted half note** fills a whole bar of 3/4. The dot adds half the note's length: 2 + 1 = 3 beats.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is this in 3 or in 4?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** 3 (waltz) You can hear the pattern repeat every three beats: ONE two three.

Practise · A little waltz

Count "1 2 3" in every bar. Rests are skipped automatically, but count them anyway.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

---

11. Kum Ba Yah

A spiritual in 3/4, starting with two pickup notes.

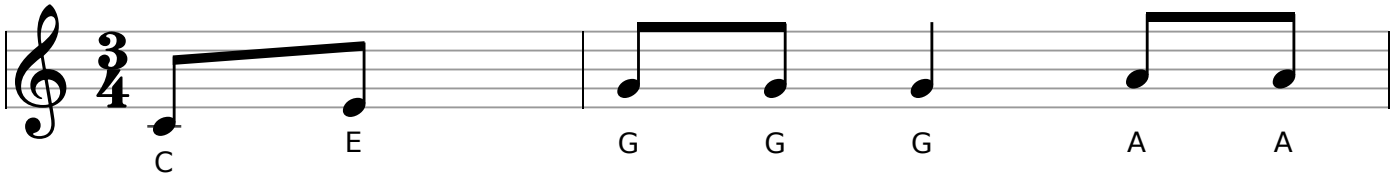
Three beats in a bar

Kum Ba Yah is a spiritual, first written down in the 1920s. It's in **3/4**: count "**1** 2 3" in every bar.

It starts with two **pickup** eighth notes, C and E, on beat 3. Each line climbs to G and holds it, and the last line comes home to C.

Practise · Kum Ba Yah

Count "3 and" for the pickup, then "1 2 3". Smooth and gentle.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

12. Dotted rhythms: Largo

Dvořák's 'Goin' Home' melody.

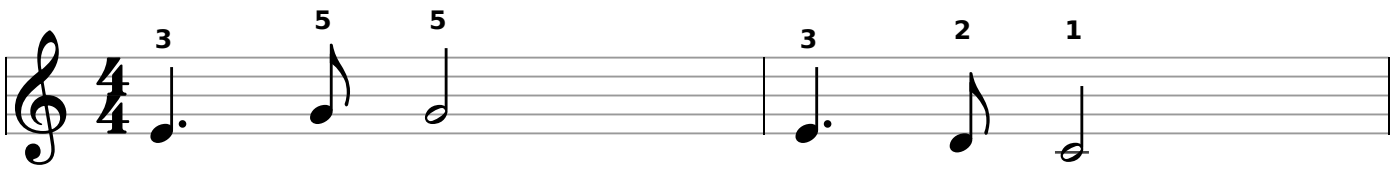
The dotted quarter

A **dotted quarter note** lasts a beat and a half. It's usually followed by a short eighth note to fill the beat: "long… short".

This rhythm opens the slow movement (Largo) of Dvořák's **New World Symphony** (1893). Listen before you play.

Practise · Largo, New World Symphony

Right hand in C position. Play it slowly and sweetly, holding the long notes.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

13. Muss i denn

A German farewell song with dotted quarters.

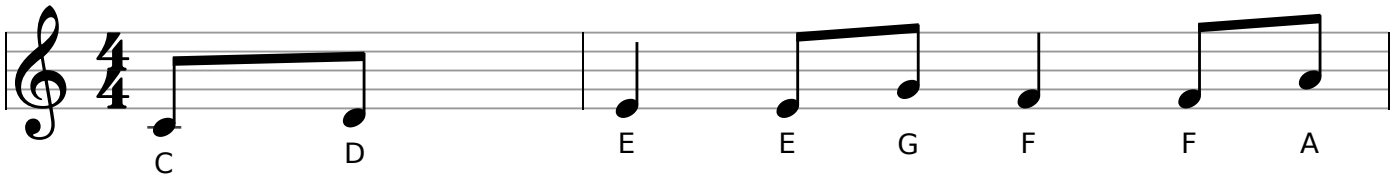
A farewell song

Muss i denn ("Must I, then, leave the little town?") is a German folk song from the 1820s. Elvis Presley sang it in English as "Wooden Heart".

It starts with two pickup eighths, C and D. In the middle section, look for the **dotted quarter notes** you just learned: "**1**-2 and", long then short.

Practise · Muss i denn

Bouncy, at a walking pace. Feel the long-short of each dotted quarter.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

14. Repeat signs

Two dots that tell you to play it again.

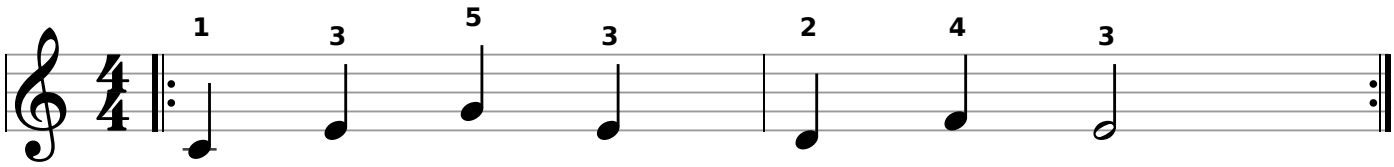
Play it again

A thick bar line with **two dots** is a **repeat sign**. When you reach the dots facing backwards, go back to the matching sign facing forwards (or to the very start, if there isn't one) and play that part again.

Composers use repeats to save paper. Sometimes the second time through has a different ending, marked with brackets numbered **1.** and **2.**: skip the first bracket on the way through again.

Practise · Repeat drill

When you reach the repeat sign, jump back and play those two bars again.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Twinkle, with a repeat

"Up above the world so high, like a diamond in the sky" is the same music twice, so it's written once with repeat signs.

15. Fox, You Stole the Goose

A German children's song in 2/4, with a repeat.

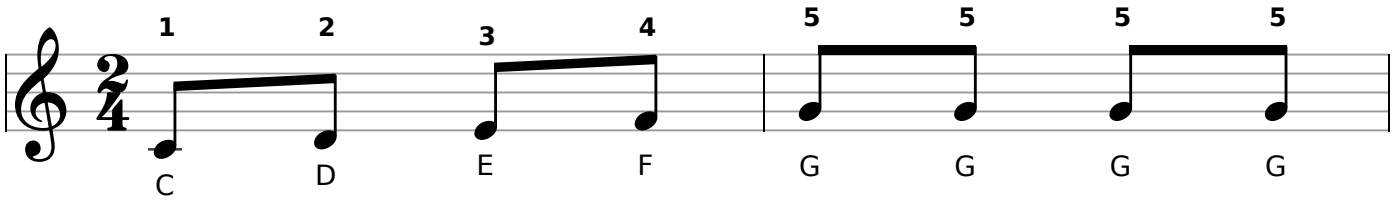
Two beats in a bar

Fuchs, du hast die Gans gestohlen ("Fox, you've stolen the goose, give it back!") is a German children's song. It's in **2/4**: just two beats per bar, mostly running eighth notes.

"Gib sie wieder her" ("give it back") comes twice, so it's written once between **repeat signs**.

Practise · Fox, You Stole the Goose

Run up C D E F G. Play the bars inside the repeat signs twice.



Opening example · 2/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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16. Reading hands together

Ode to Joy from the grand staff.

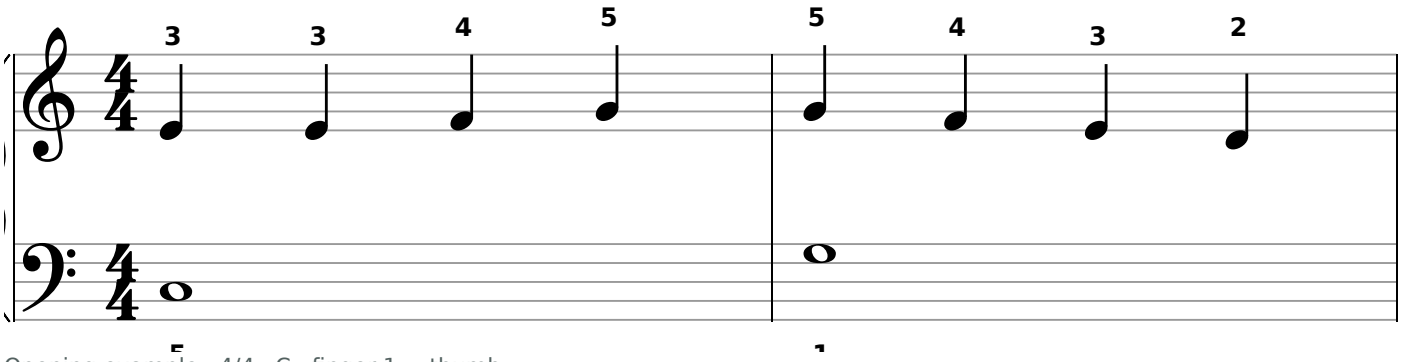
Reading two staves

Reading both staves at once is a skill that grows slowly. A good habit: before you play, look at the **bottom staff** for each bar. The left hand changes less often, so it's easier to plan ahead.

You already know this piece. Now read it from real sheet music.

Practise · Ode to Joy on the grand staff

Read both staves. The app waits for both hands where they play together.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

17. Intervals: 2nds to 5ths

Measuring the distance between two notes.

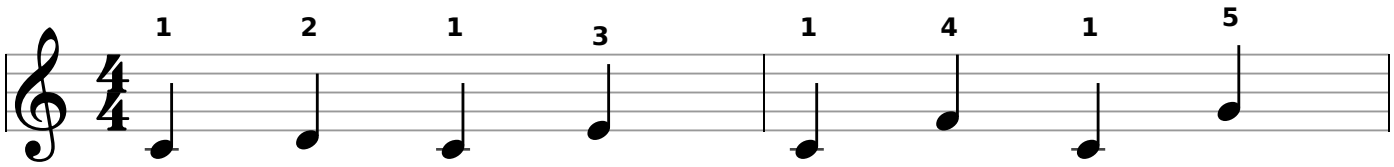
Counting the distance

The distance between two notes is called an **interval**. To name one, count the letters from the first note to the second, **counting both**. C to D is a **2nd** (C, D). C to E is a **3rd** (C, D, E). C to F is a **4th**, and C to G is a **5th**.

On the staff: a 2nd goes line to space, a 3rd goes line to line, and a 5th goes line to line with one line skipped. In C position, the interval matches the gap in finger numbers plus one: thumb to finger 3 is a 3rd.

Practise · Growing intervals

Keep your thumb on C and stretch a little further each time: 2nd, 3rd, 4th, 5th.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review**
>
> What interval is this?
>
> **Answer:** A 3rd E to G: count E, F, G. Three letters, so it's a 3rd (line to line).

> **Review**
>
> What interval is this?
>
> **Answer:** A 5th D, E, F, G, A: five letters, so it's a 5th.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is this a 2nd or a 5th?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** A 5th A 5th sounds open and wide. A 2nd is right next door and sounds crunchy when played together.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** A 2nd E and F are neighbours: a 2nd.

18. Amazing Grace

A gentle waltz-time hymn, read from the staff.

Amazing Grace

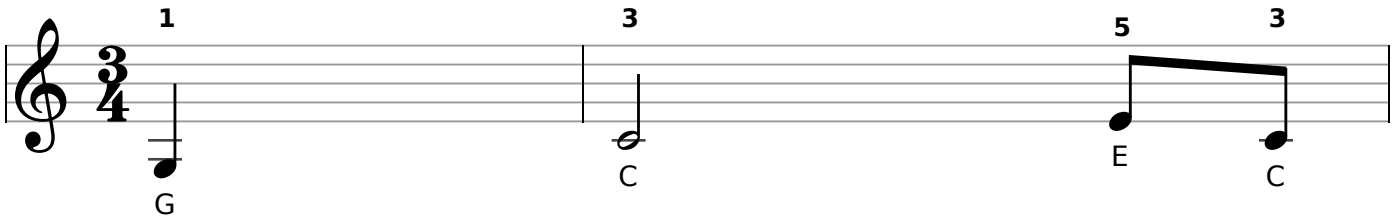
John Newton wrote the words in 1772. The tune everyone knows, **"New Britain"**, was joined to them in 1835.

It's in **3/4** and starts with a **pickup**: a single beat before the first full bar. Count "3" for the pickup, then "**1** 2 3" in every bar.

Hand position: thumb on the **G below Middle C**. In the second line your hand moves up so the thumb sits on Middle C, and then comes back.

Practise · Line 1

Thumb on low G. Read the staff; the little curls are eighth notes.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 2

Thumb moves to Middle C. Hold the high G for three beats.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

Two silent beats, then up high again. Then back to low G for the ending.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

19. Simple Gifts

A Shaker song full of skipping eighth notes, read from the staff.

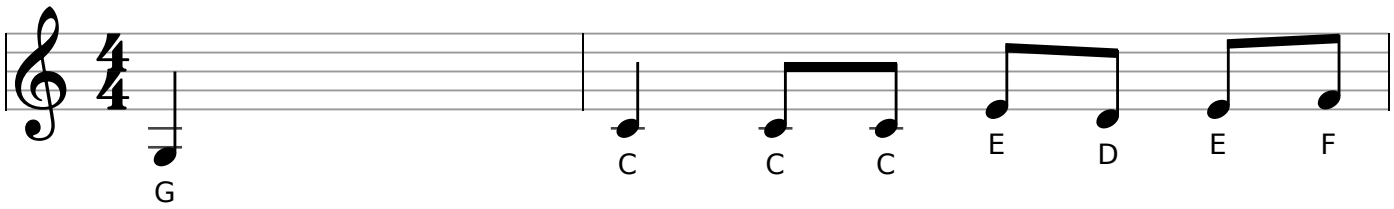
Simple Gifts

Joseph **Brackett**, a Shaker elder in Maine, wrote "Simple Gifts" in 1848. A century later Aaron **Copland** made it famous in his ballet *Appalachian Spring*.

It starts with a one-beat **pickup** on the G below Middle C. After that, look for pairs of **eighth notes**: two notes in the time of one beat. Say "1 and 2 and" as you play them.

Practise · Line 1

"'Tis the gift to be simple, 'tis the gift to be free..."



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 2

"'Tis the gift to come down where we ought to be." It ends on Middle C.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

The second half starts high on G, then dances back down.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole song, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

20. Away in a Manger

A lullaby carol in 3/4 that floats gently downward.

Away in a Manger
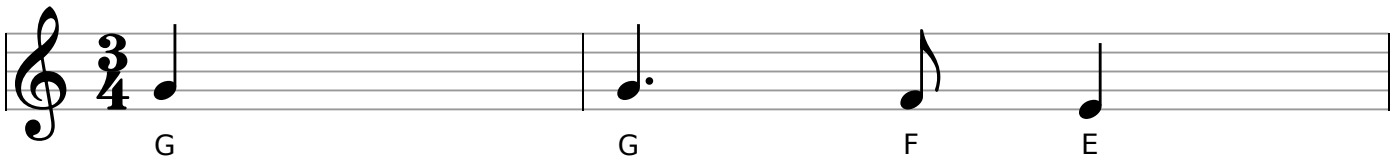
This American tune by James R. **Murray** was published in 1887 and is sung at Christmas all over North America.

It's a lullaby in **3/4**, like Amazing Grace, and starts with a one-beat **pickup**. Each line begins high on G and drifts down, step by step, below Middle C.

Watch for the **dotted quarter** followed by an eighth: a gentle "lo-ong, short".

Practise · First half

"Away in a manger, no crib for a bed…" Let it rock gently, 1 2 3.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Second half

"The stars in the sky…" Same start, then a new ending that settles on Middle C.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole carol, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Find treble and bass notes using the staff and landmark notes.
- ☐ Count the note values, rests, ties, and pickups introduced here.
- ☐ Follow repeat signs and read both staves together.
- ☐ Read a short unfamiliar passage before turning on hints.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?

Moving around

New positions, sharps and flats, thumb-under, and your first scales.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Landmark notes and ledger lines
2. G position
3. Sharps and flats
4. Doxology in G major
5. O Christmas Tree
6. D position and F sharp
7. Shall We Gather at the River
8. F position and B flat
9. What a Friend We Have in Jesus
10. Thumb under
11. The C major scale
12. G and F major scales
13. Major and minor
14. Go Down, Moses
15. Hark! The Herald Angels Sing
16. Joy to the World
17. O Come, All Ye Faithful

1. Landmark notes and ledger lines

Signposts on the staff, and notes above and below it.

Landmark notes

Instead of counting up from the bottom line every time, good readers learn a few **landmark notes** and read from the nearest one.

Treble **G** sits on the line the treble clef curls around. Bass **F** sits on the line between the bass clef's two dots. **Middle C** sits on a short line between the staves. Two more Cs make easy signposts: treble C in the **third space**, and bass C in the **second space**.

Practise · Landmark hops

Hop between the landmarks: Middle C, treble G, treble C. Use whatever fingers feel comfortable.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass landmarks

Now your left hand: bass C, bass F, and up to Middle C.

Ledger lines

Music can go higher or lower than the five lines. Short extra lines called **ledger lines** extend the staff. Middle C is the one you already know.

Keep the pattern going: above the top line of the treble staff (F) comes G in the space just above, then **A on the first ledger line**, and C on the second. Below the bass staff it's the mirror: F hangs just under the bottom line, and **E sits on the first ledger line**.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** A One ledger line above the treble staff is A: top line F, space G, ledger line A.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** C The third space of the treble staff is treble C, one of the landmarks. (It's the C in F-A-C-E.)

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** F The line between the bass clef's dots is F. That's why it's also called the F clef.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** E One ledger line below the bass staff is E: bottom line G, space F, ledger line E.

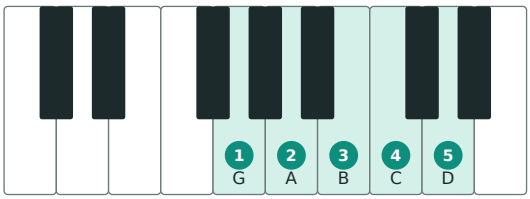
2. G position

Moving your hands to a new home.

A new home

Your hands don't have to stay on C. Move the right hand up so the thumb sits on the **G** just above Middle C. Now your fingers cover **G A B C D**.

The pattern of fingers is exactly the same as before. Only the starting note changed.

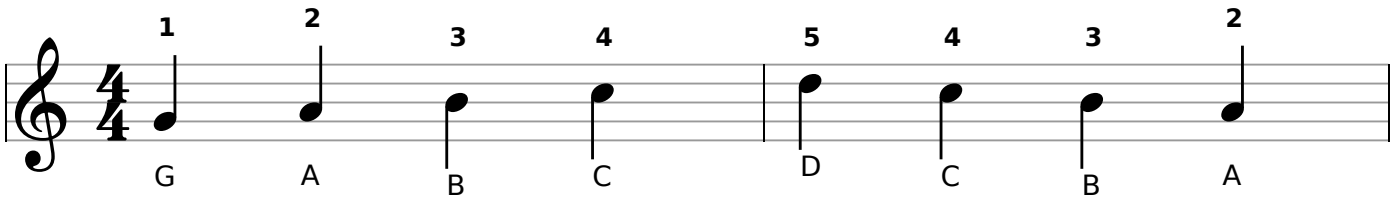


Right hand G position: thumb on G

Figure 4.1 · A new home

Practise · Right hand G position

Thumb on G. Play up and down: G A B C D C B A G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand G position

Left pinky on the G below Middle C. Play up and down.

Practise · Ode to Joy in G

The same tune, moved to G position. Same fingers as before!

3. Sharps and flats

Naming the black keys.

Up a little, down a little

The black keys are named after their white neighbours. A **sharp** ♯ means "one key higher" and a **flat** ♭ means "one key lower".

So the black key just right of F is **F**♯ (F sharp). The black key just left of B is **B**♭ (B flat). Every black key has two names: F♯ is the same key as G♭.

The distance from any key to its very nearest neighbour is called a **half step**.

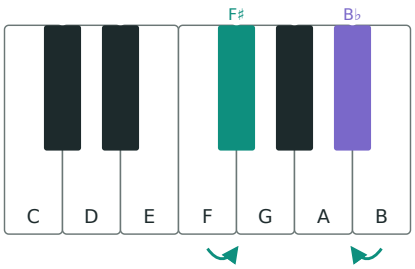
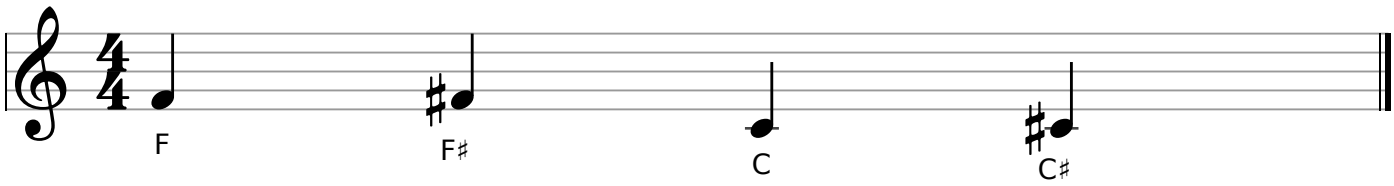


Figure 4.2 · Up a little, down a little

Practise · Find the sharps

Play F, then F sharp. Then C, then C sharp.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Find the flats

Play B, then B flat. Then E, then E flat.

> **Review**
>
> F♯ is the black key…
>
> **Answer:** Just right of F Sharp means one key higher, so F♯ is just to the right of F.

> **Review**
>
> What is another name for the black key between C and D?
>
> **Answer:** D♭ It's both C♯ (C raised) and D♭ (D lowered).

Natural signs and key signatures

A **natural** ♮ cancels a sharp or flat: play the white key.

Sometimes the sharps or flats are written once at the start of every line. That's a **key signature**. A sharp on the F line means **every F is F♯** unless you see a natural. You'll meet this in the next lessons.

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4. Doxology in G major

The key it's sung in, with its one sharp.

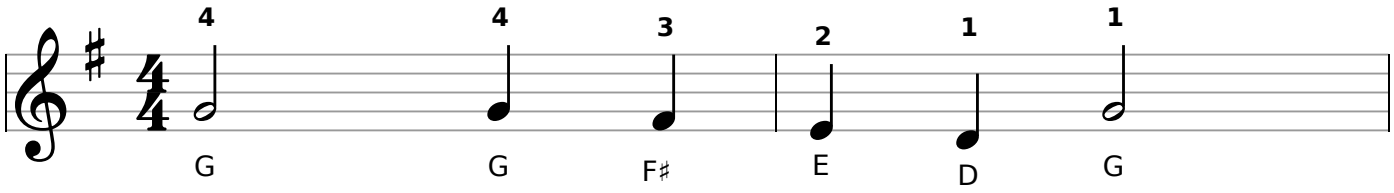
The hymnal key

Hymnals print the Doxology in **G major**, so a congregation can sing it comfortably. G major has one sharp, **F♯**, shown at the start of every line.

The melody is exactly the same shape as before, just starting on G instead of C. Only one note is sharp: the F♯ in lines one and three.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

Finger 4 on G above Middle C. Walk down G, F♯, E, D, then thumb back to G and up.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

Line three dips to E and climbs F♯, G. Line four starts on the high D.

Practise · The whole Doxology in G

From the top, in the hymnal key.

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5. O Christmas Tree

The German carol in G major, with an F sharp.
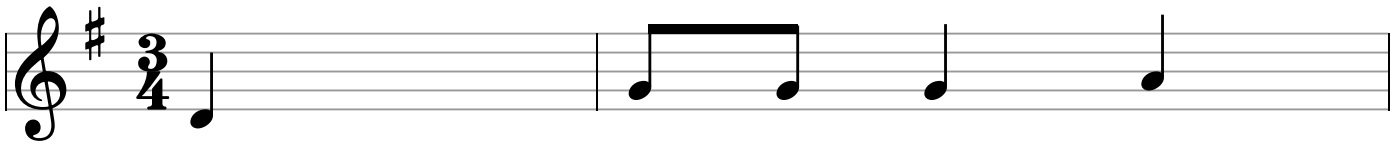
O Tannenbaum

O Tannenbaum is the German carol known in English as "O Christmas Tree". It's in **G major**, so watch for the one **F♯** near the end of the first line.

It's in 3/4 with a one-beat pickup on D. The middle part climbs higher, up to E.

Practise · O Christmas Tree

Count "3" for the pickup D, then "1 2 3".



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

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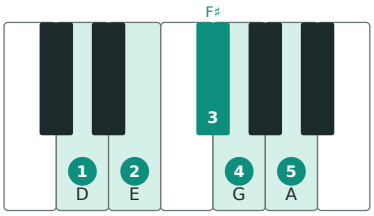
6. D position and F sharp

A five-finger position with a black key.

Major five-finger pattern

Listen to C D E F G: it sounds bright and happy. That sound is called **major**. To get the same sound starting on D, you need one black key: **D E F♯ G A**.

Your third finger reaches forward onto F♯. Keep the hand relaxed and let the finger move in, rather than twisting the wrist.

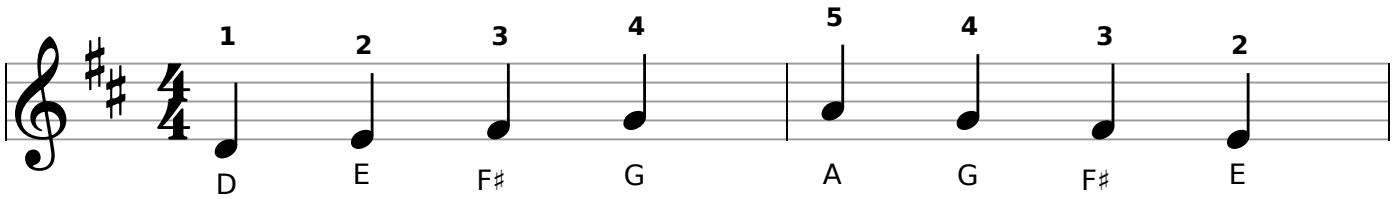


D position: finger 3 on the black key F♯

Figure 4.3 · Major five-finger pattern

Practise · D position

Thumb on D. Play up and down, with finger 3 on F sharp.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Mary in D

The key signature has two sharps, but in this tune only F♯ appears.

7. Shall We Gather at the River

Robert Lowry's hymn in D major.
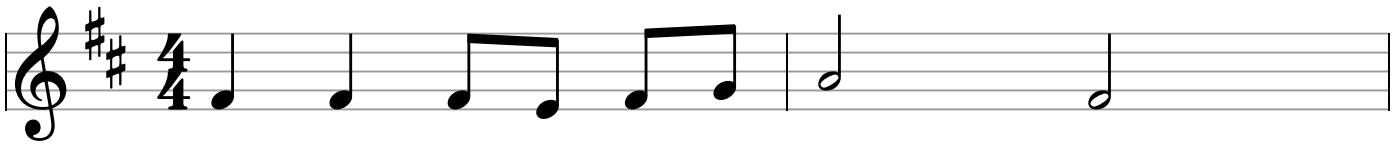
A hymn in D

Robert Lowry wrote **Shall We Gather at the River**, words and tune, in 1864. It sits in your new **D position**, with F♯ under finger 3, and reaches up to the high D in the refrain.

The refrain has a **C♯** just below the high D.

Practise · Verse

Thumb on D. The verse stays close to home.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Shall We Gather at the River

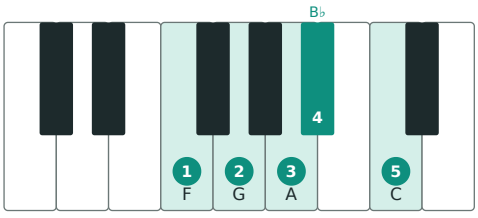
Verse and refrain.

8. F position and B flat

A five-finger position with a flat.

F major position

Starting on F, the major pattern needs a **B♭**: **F G A B♭ C**. The key signature of F major has one flat on the B line.

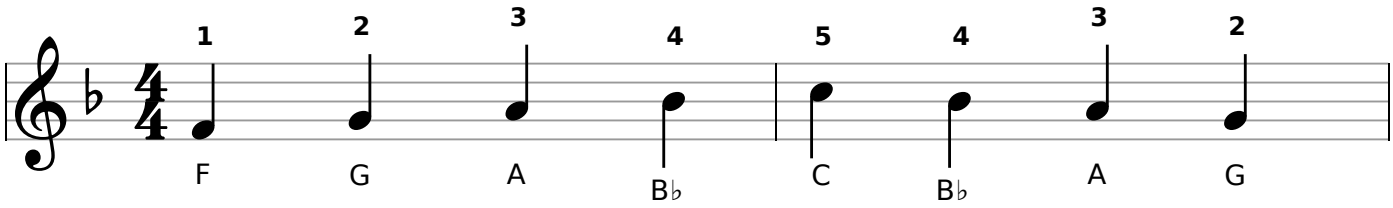


F position: finger 4 on B♭

Figure 4.4 · F major position

Practise · F position

Thumb on F. Finger 4 plays B flat.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hot Cross Buns in F

Hand in F position: A G F with fingers 3 2 1.

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9. What a Friend We Have in Jesus

A much-loved hymn in F major, with B flat.
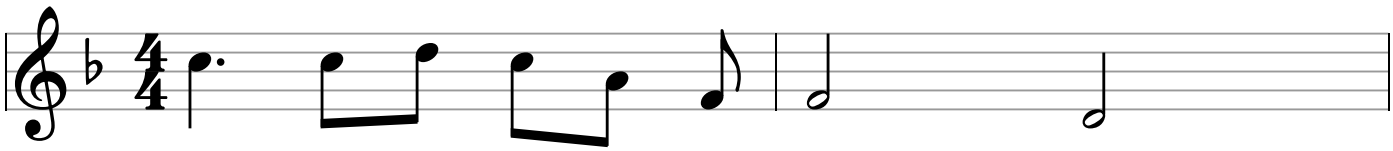
A hymn in F

Joseph Scriven wrote these words in 1855 for his mother, and Charles Converse's tune came in 1868. It's in **F major**, so every B is **B♭**.

Each line starts with a **dotted quarter** and then runs in eighth notes. Line five has one F♯, just before the climb up to the high D.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"What a friend we have in Jesus, all our sins and griefs to bear."



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · What a Friend We Have in Jesus

All eight lines. Lines 1, 3 and 7 are the same tune.

10. Thumb under

The trick for playing more than five notes.

Crossing the thumb

Five fingers, but eight notes in C to C. The solution: after finger 3 plays E, **tuck your thumb under** your hand to play F. Then fingers 2 3 4 5 continue.

Keep your wrist level and smooth. The thumb should start moving under while finger 3 is still playing, so there's no bump.

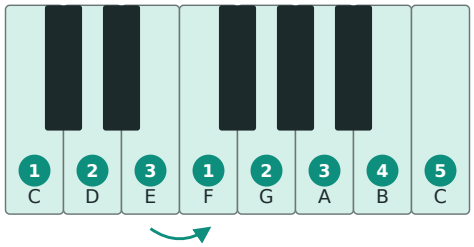
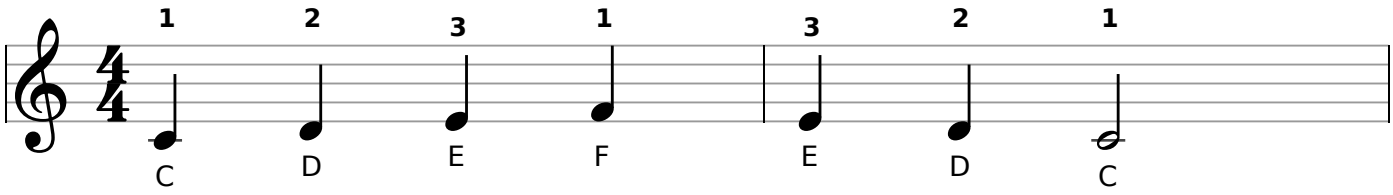


Figure 4.5 · Crossing the thumb

Practise · Thumb-under warm-up

Play C D E, then pass the thumb under to F. Back and forth.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Finger 3 over

Coming back down, it's the reverse: after the thumb plays F, finger **3 crosses over** the thumb to play E.

Practise · Crossing over

Play G F with 2 1, then cross 3 over to E. Then D C.

11. The C major scale

Eight notes, one octave, both hands.

What is a scale?

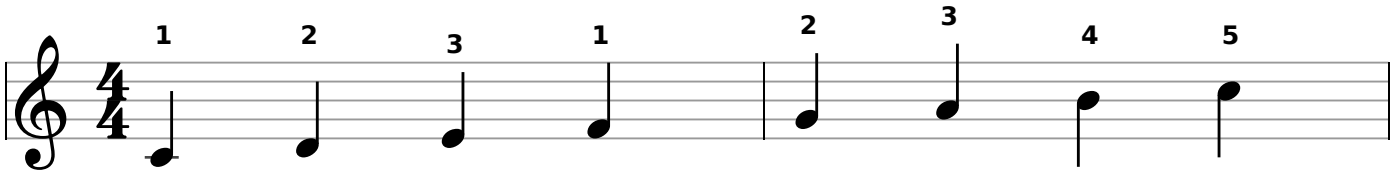
A **scale** is a ladder of notes, going up or down by step. The **C major scale** uses all the white keys from C to C: eight notes, called an **octave**.

Scales are the push-ups of piano playing. Pianists practice them every day to build even, smooth fingers.

Right hand fingering: **1 2 3, thumb under, 1 2 3 4 5**.

Practise · Right hand, up and down

Play the C major scale up and back down. Thumb under on the way up, 3 over on the way down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

The left hand scale

The left hand goes **5 4 3 2 1**, then finger **3 crosses over** the thumb to A, then **2 1**.

Coming back down it's the mirror: **1 2 3** for C B A, then the **thumb tucks under** to G, and **2 3 4 5** finish the scale.

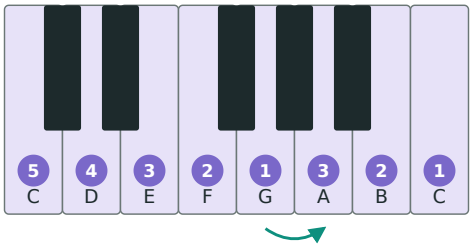


Figure 4.6 · The left hand scale

Practise · Left hand, up and down

Left hand: 5 4 3 2 1, cross 3 over, 2 1. Then back down.

Practise · Hands together (challenge)

Both hands, very slowly. The fingers cross at different moments, so think about each one.

12. G and F major scales

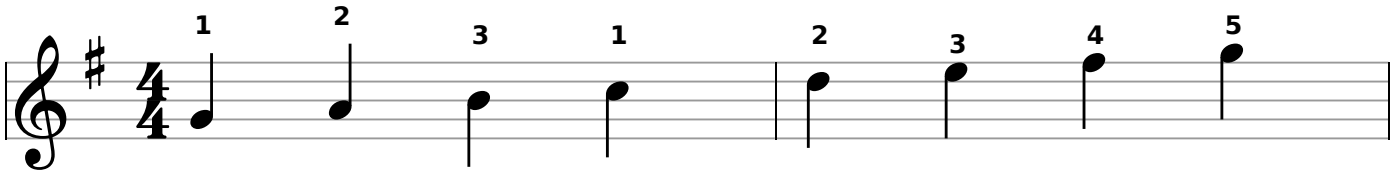
Scales with one sharp and one flat.

G major has F♯

The **G major scale** is G A B C D E **F♯** G. It uses the same fingering as C major: 1 2 3, thumb under, 1 2 3 4 5. Finger 4 lands on F♯.

Practise · G major, right hand

Thumb on G. Remember the F sharp near the top.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

F major has B♭

The **F major scale** is F G A **B♭** C D E F. Its right hand fingering is different, because a thumb on a black key is awkward: **1 2 3 4**, thumb under to C, then **1 2 3 4**.

Practise · F major, right hand

Fingers 1 2 3 4 for F G A B flat, thumb under to C, then 1 2 3 4.

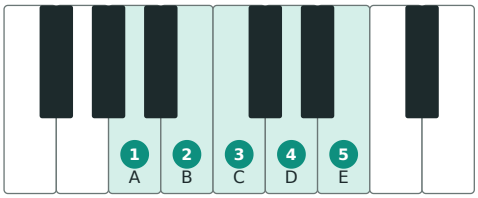
13. Major and minor

Happy and sad sounds, and A minor.

A minor position

Music in a **minor** key often sounds sad, mysterious or serious. Compare C D E (major) with A B C (minor). The middle note is closer to the bottom.

Put your right thumb on the A just below Middle C. Your fingers now cover **A B C D E**, all white keys.

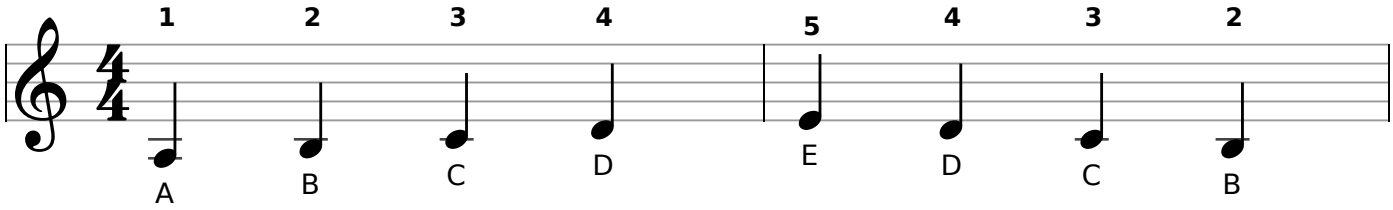


A minor position: thumb on A

Figure 4.7 · A minor position

Practise · A minor five-finger

Up and down in A minor. Listen to the darker colour.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Major or minor?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Major That was C major: bright and open.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Minor That was A minor: a darker, more wistful colour.

Practise · A sad little song

A melody in A minor. Play it gently.

---

14. Go Down, Moses

A spiritual in A minor.
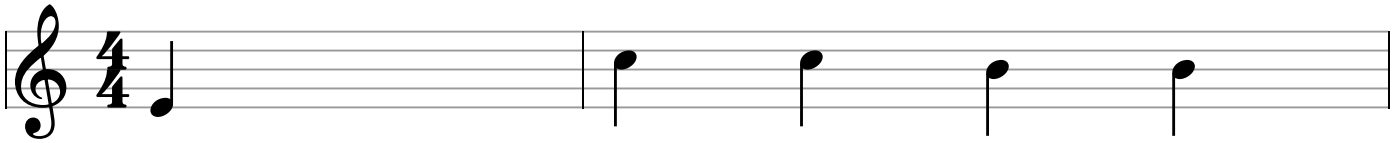
A minor spiritual

Go Down, Moses is an African American spiritual about the escape from Egypt. It's in a **minor** key, which gives it its serious, longing sound. Here it's in A minor.

Listen for the **G♯** in "let my people go": it pulls up strongly to A.

Practise · Go Down, Moses

Start on E, then up to C. Give the long notes their full value.



Opening example · 4/4 · Am · finger 1 = thumb

15. Hark! The Herald Angels Sing

Mendelssohn's carol, in F major with B♭.

Hark! The Herald Angels Sing

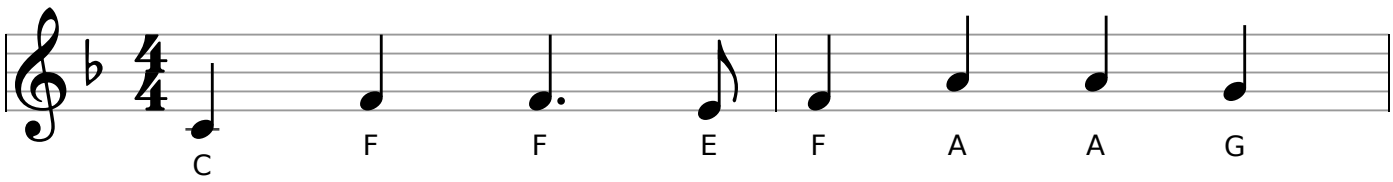
Charles Wesley wrote the words in 1739. The tune comes from a piece Felix **Mendelssohn** composed in 1840, and the two were joined in 1855.

We'll play it in **F major**, so every B is **B**♭. Most of it sits in F position (thumb on F), with a few reaches: down to the C below for the opening note, and up to C and D at the top.

Look for the **dotted rhythm** ("long-short") on "her-ald" and "glo-ry".

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"Hark! the herald angels sing, Glory to the newborn King…" Then the second line ends low.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 3

"Joyful, all ye nations, rise…" Repeated high Cs, then a jump down to F.

Practise · Lines 4 and 5

"With angelic host proclaim…" and the famous ending, "Hark! the herald angels sing, Glory to the newborn King!"

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole carol, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

16. Joy to the World

A carol that opens with a whole scale, walking down from high C.

Joy to the World

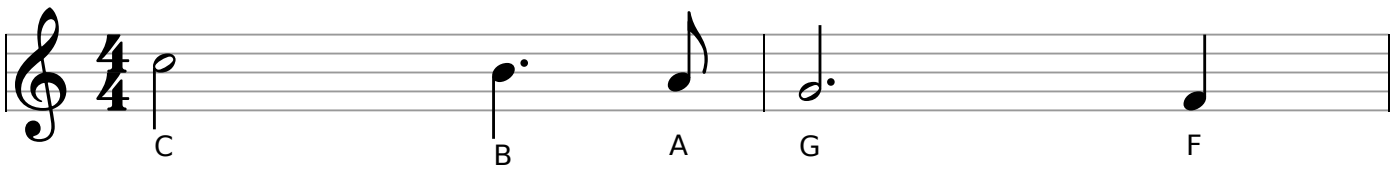
Isaac **Watts** wrote the words in 1719. The tune, called "Antioch", was arranged by Lowell **Mason** in 1839.

The first line is simply the **C major scale**, walking down from high C to Middle C. Use your scale fingering: start with finger 5 on high C, and cross finger 3 over your thumb after G.

Watch for the **dotted** notes: "long-short".

Practise · Line 1

"Joy to the world! The Lord is come." Walk all the way down the scale.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 2 and 3

"Let earth receive her King…" Climb back up to high C, then two little falling phrases.

Practise · The ending

"And heaven and nature sing…" Repeated notes, then a leap to high C and home.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole carol, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

17. O Come, All Ye Faithful

A grand Christmas hymn in G major, with F sharp.

O Come, All Ye Faithful

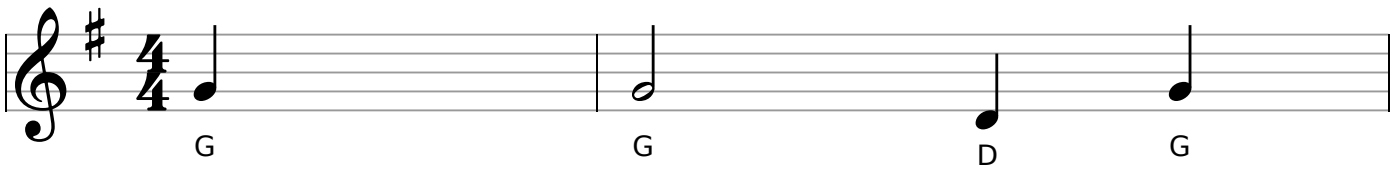
This hymn began in Latin as **"Adeste Fideles"**. The tune is usually credited to John Francis **Wade**, around 1745.

We'll play it in **G major**, so every F is **F♯**. It starts with a one-beat **pickup** on G.

It has three parts: the verse, a middle line that starts on high D ("Come and behold Him"), and the famous refrain, "O come, let us adore Him", which climbs a little higher each time.

Practise · The verse

"O come, all ye faithful, joyful and triumphant…" Remember F sharp.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · The middle line

"Come and behold Him, born the King of angels…" Start high on D.

Practise · The refrain

"O come, let us adore Him…" three times, each a step higher, then "Christ the Lord".

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Use landmark notes to move to a new position.
- ☐ Recognize sharps, flats, and the key signatures introduced here.
- ☐ Play the taught scales with their suggested fingering and relaxed thumb crossings.
- ☐ Hear and describe the difference between major and minor.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?

Playing with expression

Loud and soft, smooth and short, tempo words and the sustain pedal.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Loud and soft
2. Getting louder and softer
3. Jacob's Ladder
4. Smooth and detached
5. Go, Tell It on the Mountain
6. Slurs and phrases
7. Doxology with expression
8. Fairest Lord Jesus
9. Tempo words
10. The sustain pedal
11. All Through the Night
12. Be Thou My Vision
13. Holy, Holy, Holy

1. Loud and soft

Piano, forte, and everything in between.

Soft-loud

The piano's full name is the **pianoforte**, Italian for "soft-loud". It was the first keyboard that could play both, depending on how firmly you press the keys.

Music marks loudness with Italian letters called **dynamics**: ***p*** (piano) means soft and ***f*** (forte) means loud. A mark stays in force until the next one.

Loud doesn't mean banging. Let the weight of your arm sink into the key. For soft, use less weight but still press all the way down.

The whole family

From softest to loudest:

pp pianissimo, very soft · ***p*** piano, soft · ***mp*** mezzo-piano, medium soft · ***mf*** mezzo-forte, medium loud · ***f*** forte, loud · ***ff*** fortissimo, very loud

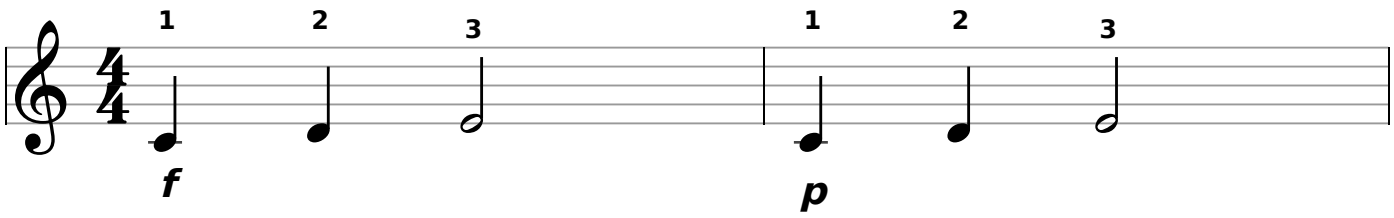
"Mezzo" means "half". If a piece has no dynamics at all, play it about ***mf***.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is the second half louder or softer than the first?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Softer It starts forte and the answer comes back piano, like an echo.

> **Review**
>
> What does mf mean?
>
> **Answer:** Medium loud mf is mezzo-forte: half loud, or medium loud.

Practise · Echo game

Play each phrase forte, then echo it piano. With listening on, I'll tell you whether I could hear the difference.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

---

2. Getting louder and softer

Crescendo and diminuendo: shaping a line.

Little by little

Crescendo (*cresc.*) means get louder little by little. **Diminuendo** (*dim.*) means get softer little by little. Sometimes they're drawn as long thin wedges called hairpins: opening for louder, closing for softer.

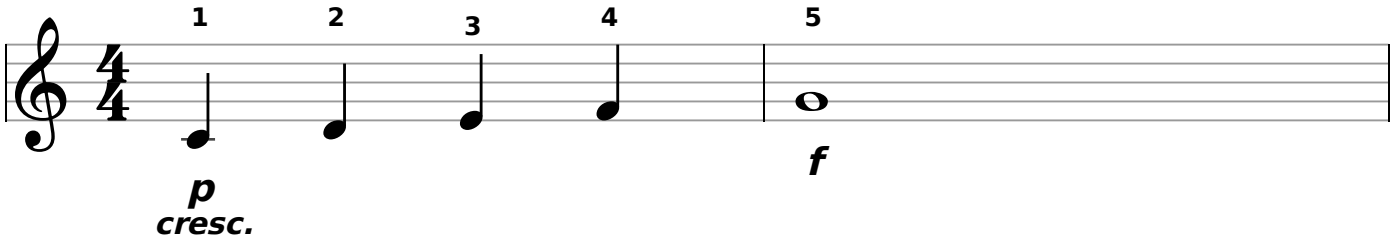
The secret is to **plan the journey**. Start a crescendo soft enough that you have somewhere to go.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Does this get louder or softer?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Louder (crescendo) It starts piano and grows to fortissimo: a crescendo.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Softer (diminuendo) It fades from very loud to very soft: a diminuendo.

Practise · Up the hill and down again

Grow louder as you climb to G, then fade away as you come back down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

---

3. Jacob's Ladder

A spiritual that grows louder as it climbs.

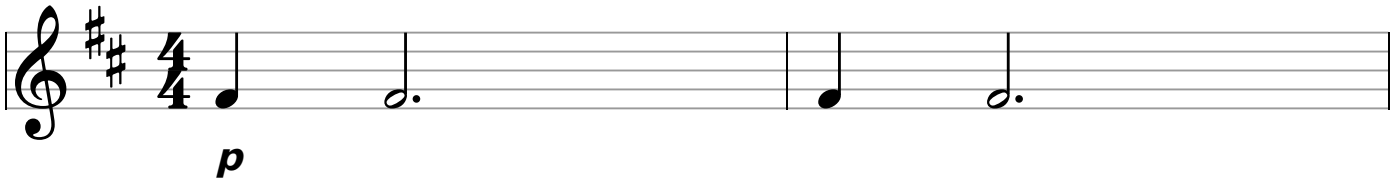
Climbing the ladder

We Are Climbing Jacob's Ladder is a spiritual whose tune climbs like its words: F♯ to A, E to B, then up to the high D.

Start **piano**, make a **crescendo** as it climbs, reach **forte** at the top, then **diminuendo** on the way down.

Practise · Jacob's Ladder

Soft, growing, loud, then fading away.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

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4. Smooth and detached

Legato and staccato: two kinds of touch.

Legato and staccato

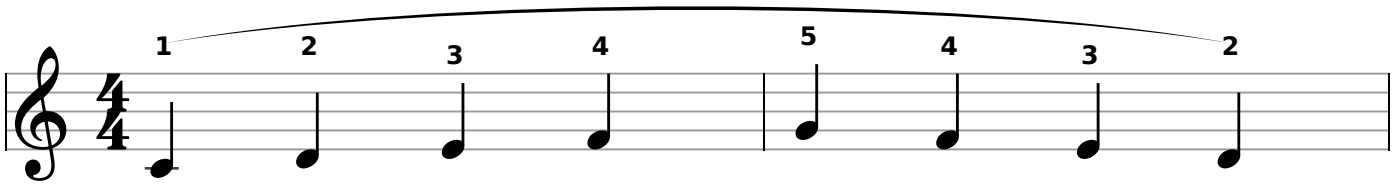
Legato means smooth and connected: hold each note until the very moment the next one sounds, so there's no gap. A curved line over several notes, called a **slur**, asks for legato.

Staccato means short and detached. A **dot** above or below the note head tells you to let go quickly, as if the key were hot. The note still gets its full beat; the rest of the beat is silence.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Smooth (legato) or detached (staccato)?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Staccato Each note is short, with a little silence after it: staccato.

Practise · Legato

Make it smooth: don't lift one finger until the next one goes down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Staccato

Bounce off each key. Small, light movements from the wrist.

Practise · Both touches

Smooth, then short. With listening on, I'll tell you if your staccato notes sounded crisp.

---

5. Go, Tell It on the Mountain
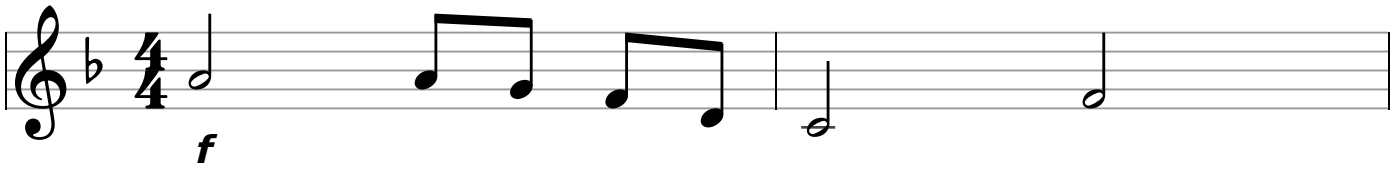
A joyful spiritual with some detached notes.

Legato and staccato together

Go, Tell It on the Mountain is a Christmas spiritual. Play it **forte** and joyful. Most of it is smooth, but "over the hills" and "Jesus" have **staccato** dots: make them short and bouncy.

Practise · Go, Tell It on the Mountain

Loud and happy. Bounce the staccato notes.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

6. Slurs and phrases

Playing a melody like a singer breathes.

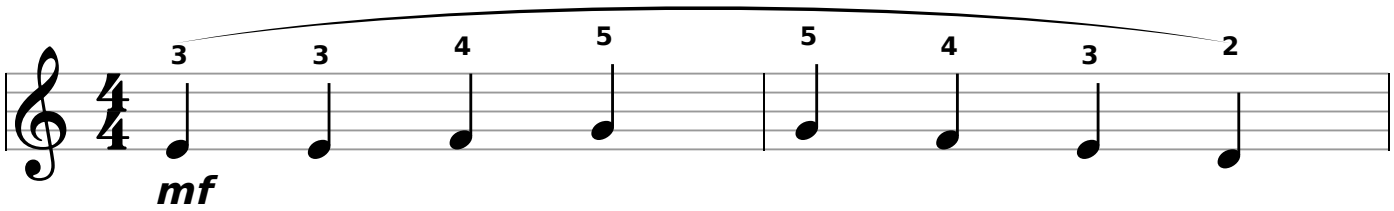
Musical sentences

Melodies are made of **phrases**, like sentences in speech. A phrase is usually two or four bars long, and a long slur often shows where it begins and ends.

Shape each phrase: lean a little towards its high point, then relax at the end. Between phrases, lift your hand gently, like a singer taking a breath.

Practise · Ode to Joy, with phrasing

Two phrases: the first mezzo-forte, the second piano like an answer. Breathe between them.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

7. Doxology with expression

Phrases, a quiet third line, and a strong ending.

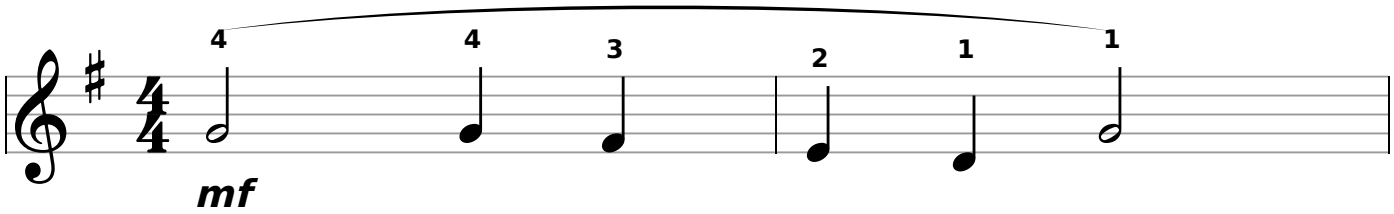
Singing it on the piano

Each line of the Doxology is one **phrase**, one breath for a singer. Shape each one with a slur, and lift gently between them.

Play the first two lines **mezzo-forte**. Make the third line **piano**, growing louder at its end, so the last line, "Praise Father, Son, and Holy Ghost", can ring out **forte**.

Practise · The Doxology, shaped

Mezzo-forte, mezzo-forte, piano getting louder, then forte. Breathe between the lines.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

8. Fairest Lord Jesus

A hymn tune shaped in six phrases.

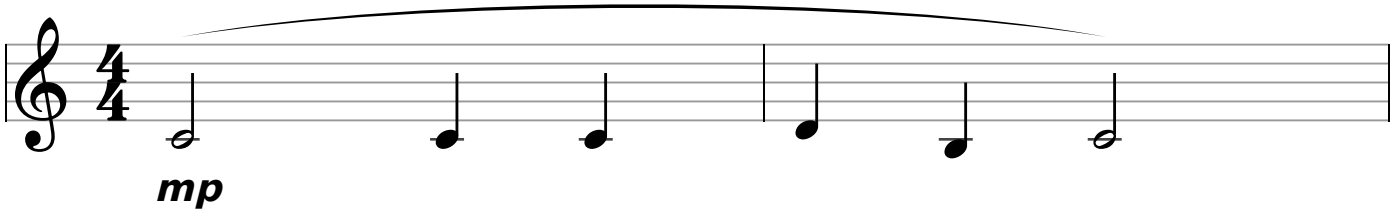
Six phrases

Fairest Lord Jesus is sung to a Silesian folk tune first printed in 1842. Each slur is one line of the hymn: play it smoothly, then lift gently before the next.

The third phrase climbs to the high C and grows a little louder. The last phrase starts mezzo-forte and fades away.

Practise · Fairest Lord Jesus

One breath per slur. Lift between them.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

9. Tempo words

Adagio, Andante, Moderato, Allegro.

How fast?

At the top of a piece you'll often find an Italian word for the **tempo**, the speed of the beat:

Adagio: slow and calm · **Andante**: at a walking pace · **Moderato**: moderate · **Allegro**: quick and cheerful

Some music also gives a number, like ♩ = 80, which means 80 beats per minute. You can set that on the metronome in Daily practice.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which tempo is this?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Adagio (slow) Slow and calm: Adagio.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Allegro (quick) Quick and bright: Allegro.

> **Review**
>
> Andante means...
>
> **Answer:** At a walking pace Andante comes from the Italian for "walking".

---

10. The sustain pedal

What the right pedal does, and how it's written.

The right pedal

The pedal on the right is the **sustain pedal**. While it's down, notes keep ringing after you let go of the keys. It makes the sound warm and full.

Music shows it with **Ped.** where you press down and * where you lift. Too much pedal blurs everything together, so lift whenever the harmony changes.

Press it with your right heel resting on the floor. If you're playing on a keyboard, a plug-in sustain pedal is worth having later on.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is the pedal down?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Yes, the notes blend and ring on The notes keep ringing and blend together: that's the sustain pedal.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this time?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** No, each note stops when released Each note stops cleanly: no pedal.

> **Review**
>
> What does * mean under the music?
>
> **Answer:** Lift the pedal Ped. means press down; * means lift.

---

11. All Through the Night

A Welsh lullaby with the sustain pedal.

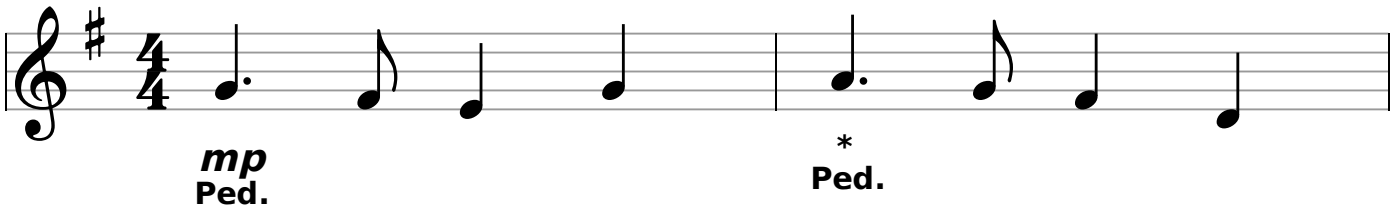
Pedal in every bar

Ar Hyd y Nos ("All Through the Night") is a Welsh folk melody, first printed in 1784. Play it gently with the **sustain pedal**.

Change the pedal at the start of every bar: lift, then press again straight away. That keeps the sound warm without blurring.

Practise · All Through the Night

Softly. Lift and press the pedal at every bar line.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

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12. Be Thou My Vision

An old Irish melody to shape with soft and loud.

Be Thou My Vision

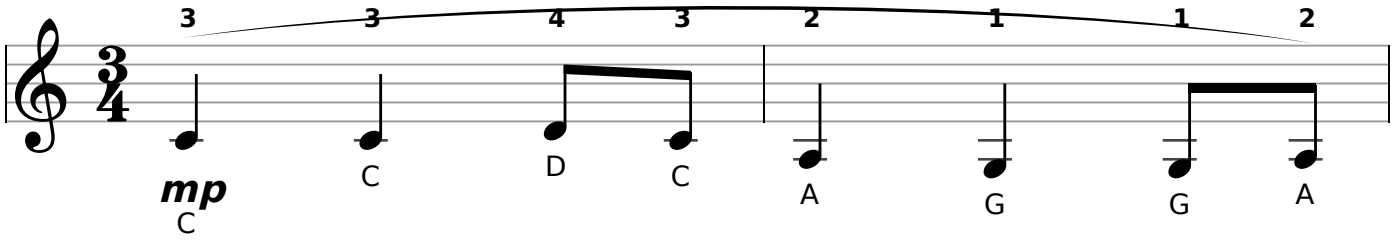
This tune, called **Slane**, is an Irish folk melody. It was paired with an ancient Irish prayer in the early 1900s and is now sung all over the world.

Use what you've learned in this unit: begin ***mp***, grow through the second line, sing out ***f*** at the top ("High King of heaven"), then let it settle back to ***p***. Keep every phrase **legato** under its slur.

It's in 3/4 and ranges from low G to high C, so your hand moves a few times. Follow the finger numbers.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2 (3/4)

"Be Thou my vision, O Lord of my heart; naught be all else to me, save that Thou art."



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4 (3/4)

"Thou my best thought, by day or by night, waking or sleeping, Thy presence my light."

Practise · Dress rehearsal (3/4)

The whole hymn, with hints. Listen to the demo first to hear the dynamics.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

---

13. Holy, Holy, Holy

A grand hymn in D major, from forte to fortissimo.

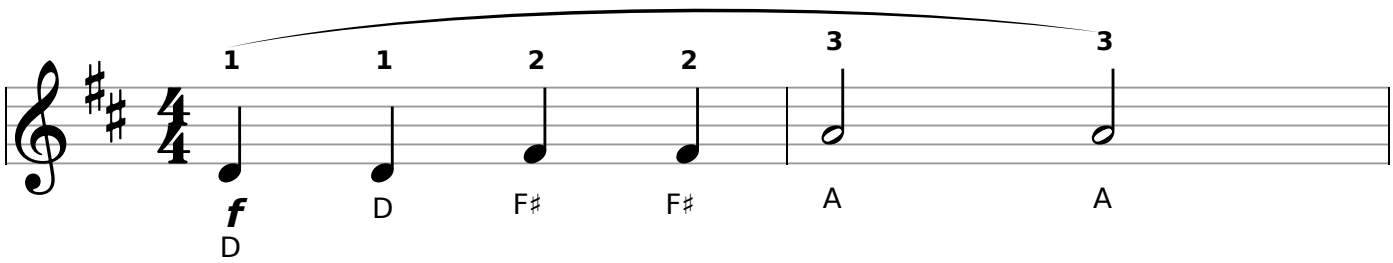
Holy, Holy, Holy

John Bacchus Dykes wrote this tune, **Nicaea**, in 1861 for Reginald Heber's words. It's one of the most majestic hymns there is.

It's in **D major**, so every F and C is sharp, just like your D position. Play the opening ***f***, drop to ***mp*** for "Early in the morning", build back up, and save your biggest sound, ***ff***, for the high D near the end.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2 [D]

"Holy, holy, holy! Lord God Almighty! Early in the morning our song shall rise to Thee."



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4 [D]

"Holy, holy, holy! Merciful and mighty! God in three Persons, blessed Trinity!"

Practise · Dress rehearsal [D]

The whole hymn, with hints. Make the dynamics big and clear.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Show a clear difference between soft and loud playing.
- ☐ Shape a crescendo, diminuendo, and musical phrase.
- ☐ Make legato and staccato sound different.
- ☐ Choose an appropriate tempo and change the pedal cleanly where taught.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?

Harmony

Chords, inversions, and accompanying a melody.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Your first chord
2. C, F and G chords
3. Rock of Ages
4. Minor chords
5. Inversions
6. Chord progressions
7. Doxology with chords
8. 'Tis So Sweet to Trust in Jesus
9. Broken chords and Alberti bass
10. Pachelbel's Canon chords
11. 6/8 time
12. Greensleeves
13. Pop Goes the Weasel
14. Silent Night
15. O Come, O Come, Emmanuel

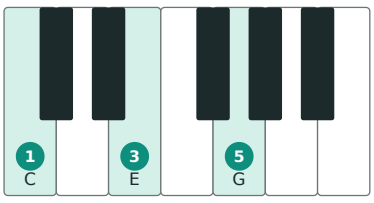
1. Your first chord

Three notes at once: the C major triad.

Stacking skips

A **chord** is several notes played together. The most common chord is a **triad**: three notes, each a skip apart. Start on C, skip to E, skip to G: that's the **C major chord**.

The bottom note, C, is the **root** and gives the chord its name.

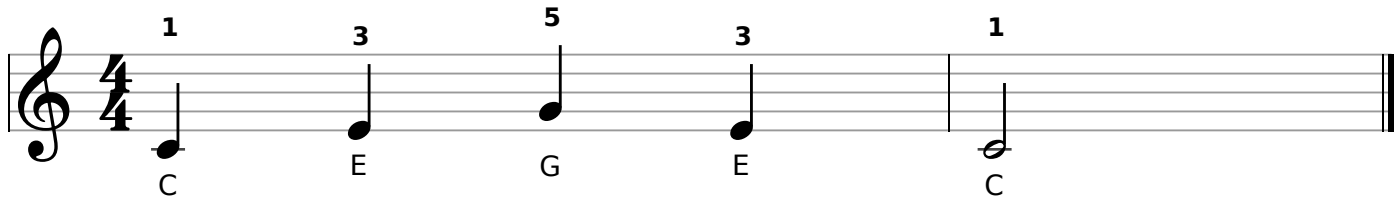


C major chord: C E G, fingers 1 3 5

Figure 6.1 · Stacking skips

Practise · Broken chord first

Play the three notes one at a time: C, E, G. Then back down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · All together

Now press C, E and G at exactly the same time, fingers 1 3 5. Land like a soft cat, all three together.

About listening for chords

Chords are much harder for a phone to hear than single notes. If the app is slow to accept a chord, try playing the notes quickly one after another (a "rolled" chord), or tap the keys on screen.

Practise · Left hand chord

Left hand: C E G below Middle C, fingers 5 3 1.

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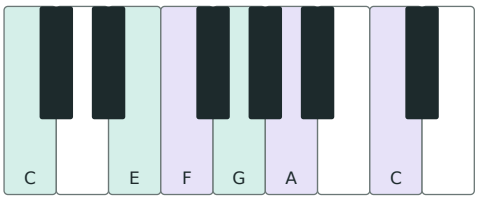
2. C, F and G chords

The three chords behind thousands of songs.

Three families

Build the same skip-skip shape on **F** and you get F A C, the **F major chord**. Build it on **G**: G B D, the **G major chord**.

C, F and G are the most important chords in the key of C. Musicians call them **I**, **IV** and **V** (one, four and five), because C, F and G are the 1st, 4th and 5th notes of the C scale.

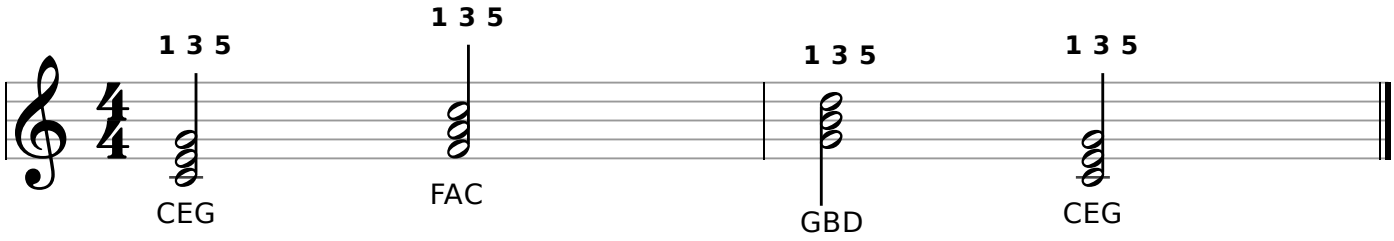


C chord (C E G) and F chord (F A C)

Figure 6.2 · Three families

Practise · Moving the chord shape

Play C chord, F chord, G chord, then C chord. Keep the hand shape and slide it along.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand chord shapes

Same thing with the left hand, fingers 5 3 1.

---

3. Rock of Ages

A hymn in 3/4 over C, F and G chords.

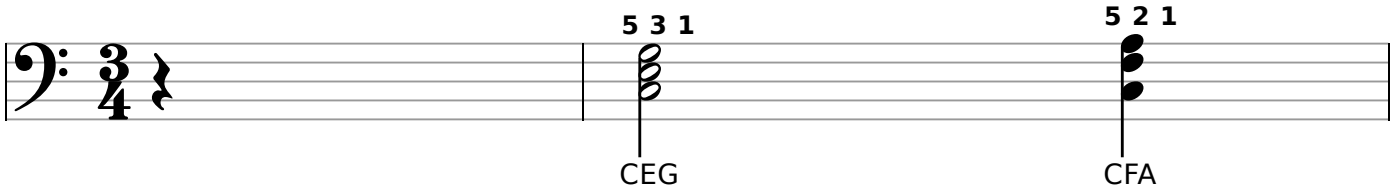
Melody over chords

Augustus Toplady wrote **Rock of Ages** in 1776, and Thomas Hastings's tune followed in 1830. The melody goes in your right hand. The left hand plays the **C, F and G chords** you just learned.

It's in 3/4 with a short pickup, two eighth notes on beat 3.

Practise · Left hand chords

Mostly C, with G and F where the melody needs them.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Rock of Ages, hands together

Melody a little louder than the chords.

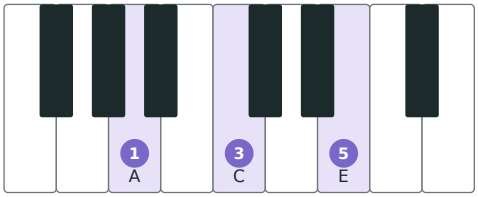
4. Minor chords

A minor, D minor and E minor.

Same shape, different colour

The white-key chord built on **A** is A C E. It has the same skip-skip shape, but it sounds **minor**, darker than C major.

The white-key chords on **D** (D F A) and **E** (E G B) are minor too. Major or minor depends on where the middle note sits.

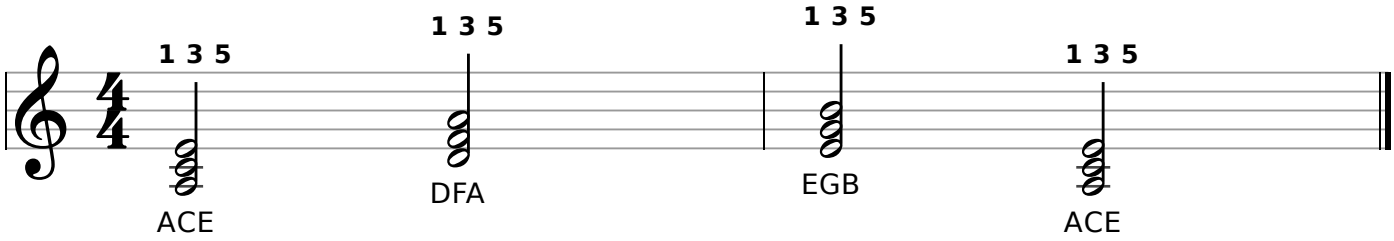


A minor chord: A C E

Figure 6.3 · Same shape, different colour

Practise · Minor chords

Play A minor, D minor, E minor, then A minor again. Listen to the mood.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Major chord or minor chord?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Minor D F A is D minor.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Major F A C is F major.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> One more.
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Minor E G B is E minor.

---

5. Inversions

Rearranging a chord so it moves smoothly.

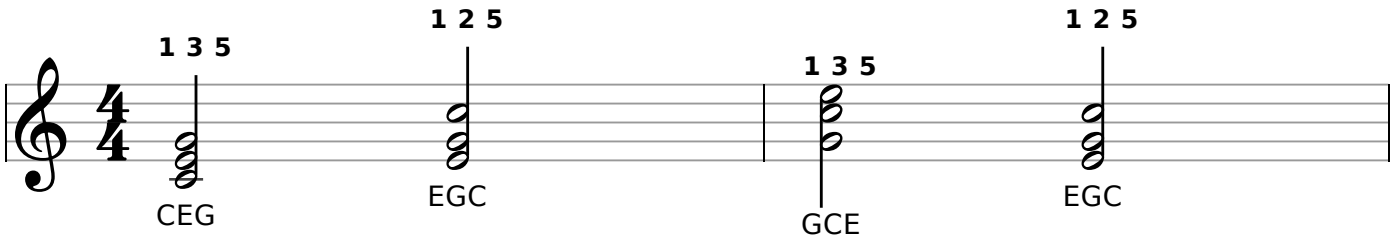
Same notes, new order

A chord doesn't have to have its root on the bottom. Move the bottom C up an octave and you get **E G C**: still a C chord, called **first inversion**. Move E up too and you get **G C E**, **second inversion**.

Inversions let your hand stay in one place while the chords change. That sounds smoother and is much easier.

Practise · C chord inversions

Root position, first inversion, second inversion, and back.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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6. Chord progressions

I, IV, V, I with smooth voicing.

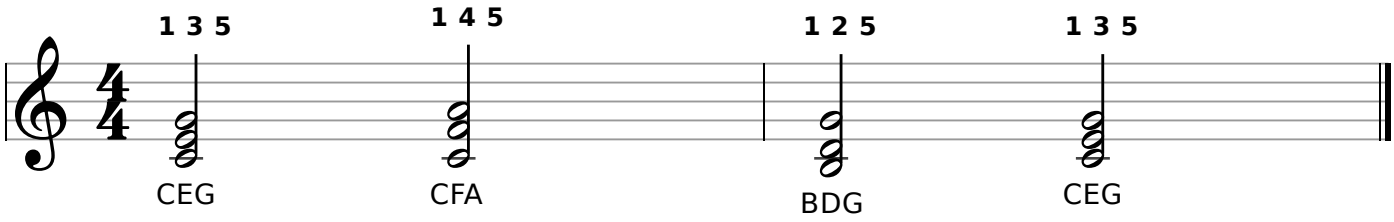
A chord journey

A **progression** is a series of chords. **C, F, G, C** (I IV V I) is the backbone of countless pieces.

Using inversions, the right hand barely moves: **C E G → C F A → B D G → C E G**. The left hand plays just the root of each chord.

Practise · Right hand only

Watch how one or two fingers move each time, and the rest stay still.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hands together

Add the left-hand roots: C, F, G, C.

---

7. Doxology with chords

The melody over left-hand C, F and G chords.

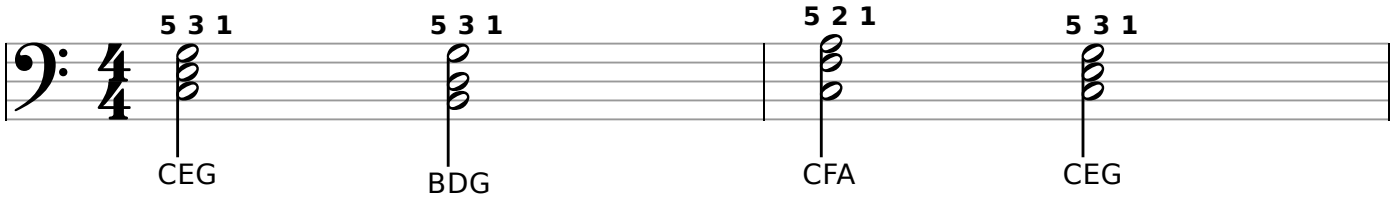
Adding harmony

Now the left hand can play **chords** under the melody, two to a bar, using the three you know: **C, F and G**.

The right hand moves up an octave, to the C above Middle C, so the hands don't bump into each other.

Practise · Left hand chords alone

Line one's chords: C, G, F, C, G, C. Keep them soft and even.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2, hands together

Melody a little louder than the chords. Change chord on beats 1 and 3.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4, hands together

The same idea for the second half.

Practise · The whole hymn with chords

All four lines, melody over chords.

8. 'Tis So Sweet to Trust in Jesus

A hymn in G over G, C and D chords.

Chords in G

Louisa Stead's words (1882) and William Kirkpatrick's tune make one of the best-loved gospel hymns. It's in **G major**, and the left hand plays **G, C and D** chords: the same I, IV, V journey you just learned, in a new key.

The chords hold for a whole bar or half a bar, so your left hand has time to move.

Practise · Left hand chords

G stays under finger 5 except for the D chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · 'Tis So Sweet, hands together

Verse and refrain.

9. Broken chords and Alberti bass

The classical way to accompany a melody.

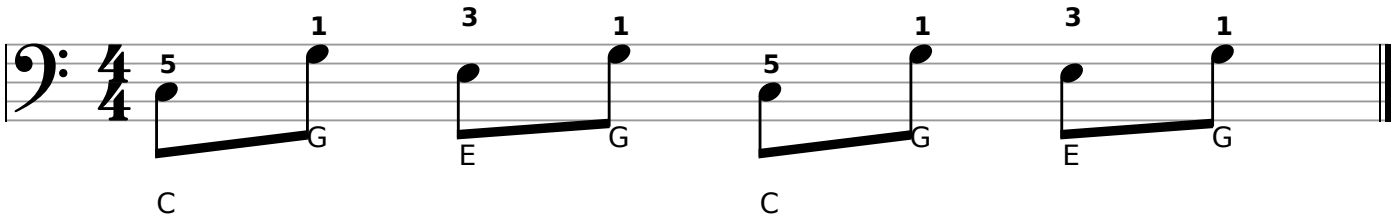
Alberti bass

Classical composers like Mozart and Haydn often break the left-hand chord into a rocking pattern: **bottom, top, middle, top**. It's called **Alberti bass**, after Domenico Alberti.

For a C chord: **C G E G**, fingers **5 1 3 1**. Keep it light and even, with the thumb barely touching its key.

Practise · Alberti on C

Left hand: C G E G, over and over. Smooth and soft.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Changing chords

Now move through C, F (C A F A), G (B G D G) and back to C.

Practise · Melody over Alberti

Right hand holds long notes while the left hand rocks underneath.

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10. Pachelbel's Canon chords

The most famous chord progression in classical music.

Eight chords on repeat

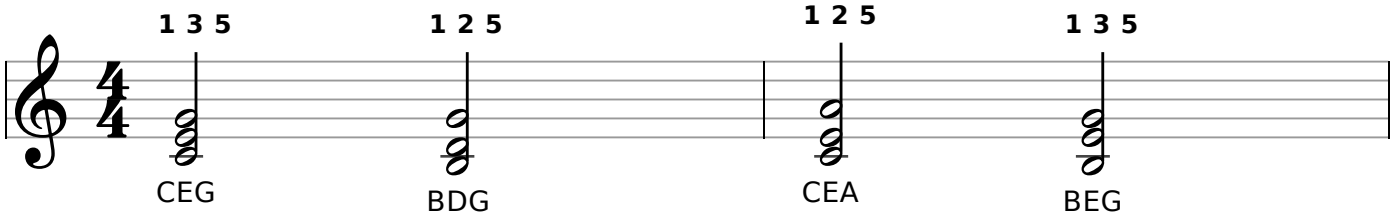
Johann Pachelbel's **Canon** (around 1700) repeats the same eight chords again and again while melodies weave over the top. Here it is moved to C major:

C – G – Am – Em – F – C – F – G

Right hand plays close inversions so it barely moves. The left hand plays the roots, mostly downward.

Practise · Right hand chords

Each chord lasts two beats. Move as few fingers as you can.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand roots

Left hand: C G A E F C F G.

Practise · The Canon progression

Hands together. Take your time between chords; the app waits.

11. 6/8 time

Six quick beats, felt as two big ones.

Two big beats

In **6/8** time there are six eighth notes in each bar, grouped in threes: "**1** 2 3 **4** 5 6". It feels like **two big beats**, each split into three. That gives it a gentle rocking or rolling feel.

A **dotted quarter note** fills one big beat (three eighths), and a **dotted half note** fills the whole bar. Silent Night, coming up in your recital, is in 6/8.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Does this rock in twos (6/8) or march in fours (4/4)?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Rocks in two (6/8) You can hear the long-short groups of three. That lilt is 6/8.

Practise · Row, Row, Row Your Boat

Count "1 2 3 4 5 6" in each bar. In "merrily, merrily", move your hand freely to reach the high C.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

12. Greensleeves

An English tune from the 1500s, in 6/8 and E minor.
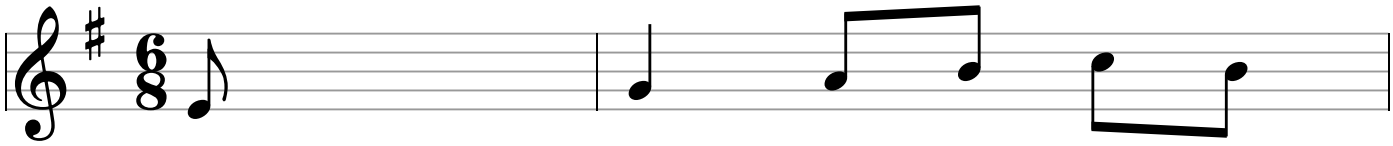
Greensleeves

Greensleeves is an English tune from the 16th century. Churches sing it at Christmas as "What Child Is This". It's in **6/8** and **E minor**.

It starts with a one-eighth pickup on E. Look for the sharps: F♯ from the key, and D♯ and C♯ near the end of each line.

Practise · Greensleeves

Two big beats per bar, each split into three.



Opening example · 6/8 · Em · finger 1 = thumb

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13. Pop Goes the Weasel

A bouncy 6/8 dance tune, with a repeat.

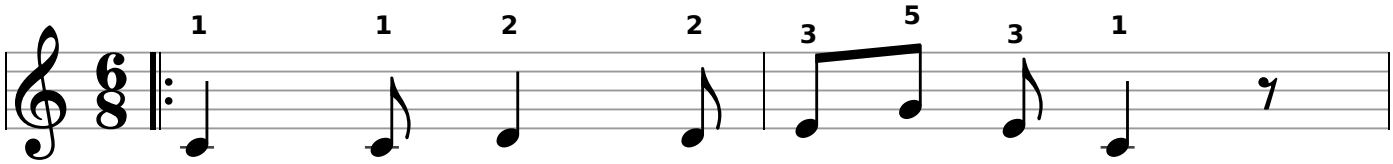
A jig

Pop Goes the Weasel was a popular dance tune in the 1850s. It's a **jig**, in 6/8, with a long-short bounce: quarter note, eighth note.

The "Pop!" is the high A. Play the whole tune twice: it's inside repeat signs.

Practise · Pop Goes the Weasel

Bouncy. Make the "Pop!" loud and short.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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14. Silent Night

Melody with left-hand chords, in gentle 6/8 time.

Silent Night

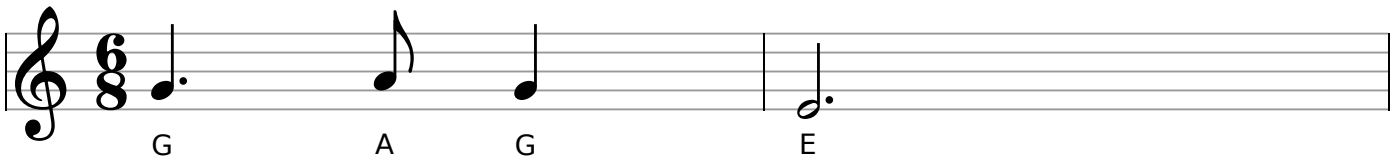
Franz Xaver **Gruber** wrote this melody for a Christmas Eve service in Oberndorf, Austria, in **1818**, with words by Joseph Mohr.

It's in **6/8**: six eighth notes per bar, felt as two slow, swaying beats. Count "**1** 2 3 **4** 5 6".

The left hand plays just **three chords** you already know: **C** (C E G), **F** (C F A) and **G** (B D G), one chord per bar, held long.

Practise · Melody, first half

"Silent night, holy night, all is calm, all is bright…"



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Melody, second half

"Round yon virgin… Holy infant… Sleep in heavenly peace."

Practise · Left-hand chords

Left hand alone: C, G and F chords. Move as little as you can between them.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

Hands together, with hints. Each chord lands with the first melody note of its bar.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

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15. O Come, O Come, Emmanuel

An ancient, haunting hymn in E minor.

O Come, O Come, Emmanuel

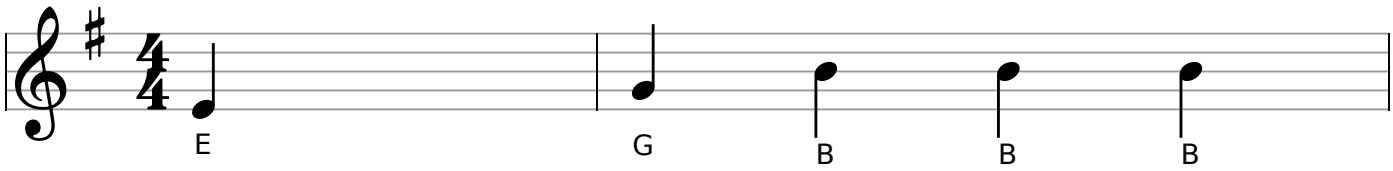
This melody comes from a **15th-century** French chant book. John Mason Neale's English words were joined to it in 1851.

It's in **E minor**, which gives it its dark, longing sound. E minor shares its key signature with G major: one sharp, **F**♯.

Play it smoothly (**legato**), like singing. Every line but the first starts with a one-beat pickup, and the refrain begins high on D: "Rejoice! Rejoice!"

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"O come, O come, Emmanuel, and ransom captive Israel…"



Opening example · 4/4 · Em · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

"That mourns in lonely exile here, until the Son of God appear."

Practise · The refrain

"Rejoice! Rejoice! Emmanuel shall come to thee, O Israel."

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, with hints. Keep it smooth and unhurried.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Build and recognize the major and minor triads introduced here.
- ☐ Move between root-position chords and inversions.
- ☐ Play the chord progression and accompaniment patterns slowly and evenly.
- ☐ Count 6/8 in two groups of three and keep the melody clear above the accompaniment.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?

Classical repertoire

Real pieces by Bach, Mozart, Beethoven and Pachelbel, simplified for you.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Minuet in G, part 1
2. Minuet in G, part 2
3. Eine kleine Nachtmusik
4. Sixteenth notes and 3/8
5. Für Elise
6. Prelude in C
7. Pachelbel's Canon
8. Schumann: Melody
9. Mozart: Minuet in F
10. Clementi: Sonatina in C
11. The complete Doxology
12. What comes next
13. Joyful, Joyful (grand finale)
14. The complete Doxology
15. Mozart: Sonata in C (opening)

1. Minuet in G, part 1

The famous minuet from the Anna Magdalena Notebook.

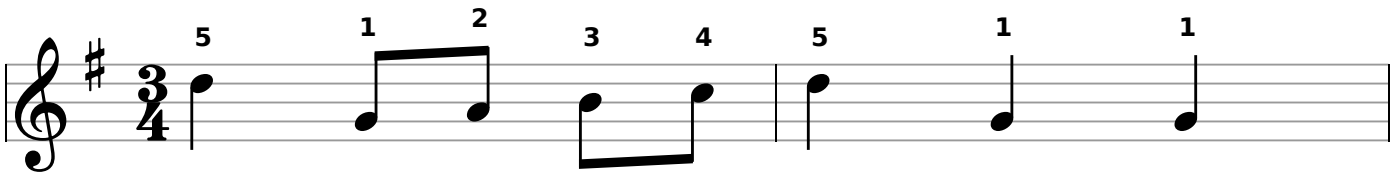
A dance from 1725

This minuet appears in a notebook Johann Sebastian Bach gave his wife, Anna Magdalena. It was long credited to Bach, but was most likely written by **Christian Petzold**. Either way, almost every piano student plays it.

A minuet is a graceful dance in **3/4**. The key is **G major**, so every F is F♯. The fingering shown is a suggestion. Your hand will shift position a few times, so watch the numbers.

Practise · Bars 1 to 4

Right hand. The eighth notes are twice as fast as the quarter notes.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bars 5 to 8

Now the second phrase, ending on a long A.

Practise · Part 1 complete

All eight bars, right hand.
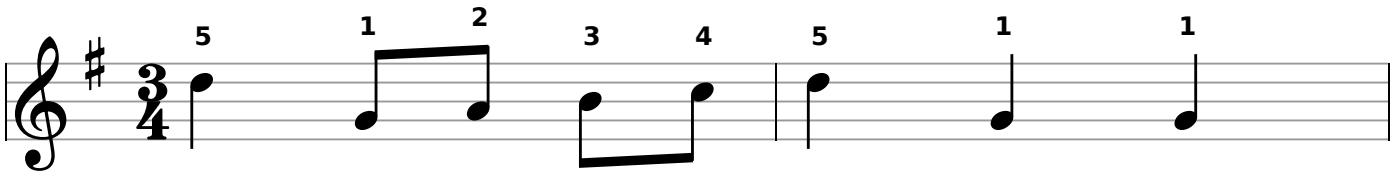
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2. Minuet in G, part 2

The second half, then hands together.

Practise · Second ending

The music repeats, but this time it ends on G: home.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

A simple left hand

Here's a simplified left hand: one long note per bar (a dotted half note, three beats). It traces the harmony underneath the melody.

Practice the left hand alone first, then put them together very slowly.

Practise · Left hand alone

One note per bar. Hold each for three beats.

Practise · Minuet in G, hands together

Both hands. The app waits on every beat where both hands play.

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3. Eine kleine Nachtmusik

Mozart's famous opening, in G major.
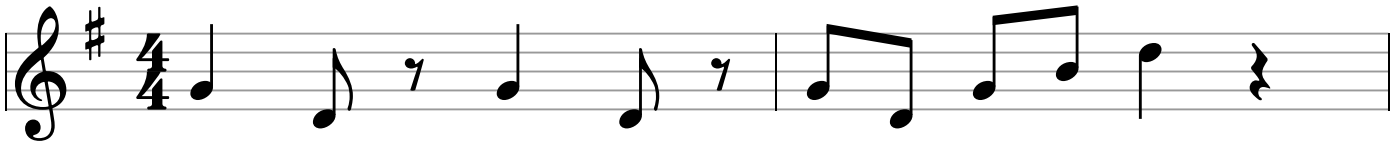
A little night music

Mozart wrote **Eine kleine Nachtmusik** ("A Little Night Music") in 1787 for strings. Its opening is one of the most recognizable bits of music ever.

It's built entirely from the **G major chord** (G B D) and then a **D major chord** (D F♯ A). Notice the short rests: they give it its crisp, cheeky feel.

Practise · The opening

Play crisply. Short notes, clean rests.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

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4. Sixteenth notes and 3/8

Four notes in a beat, and the time signature of Für Elise.

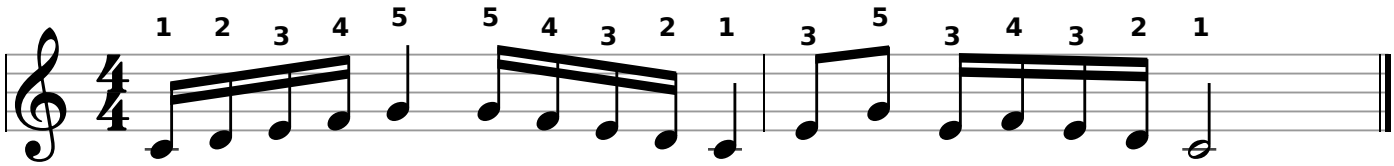
Four to a beat

A **sixteenth note** has two flags, or two beams when they're grouped. Four of them fit into one beat. Count them "**1** e and a, **2** e and a".

Practise them slowly and evenly. Speed comes later, by itself.

Practise · Even sixteenths

Say "1 e and a" for the quick notes, and keep them all the same length.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

3/8 time

3/8 means three eighth notes per bar. It goes by quickly, so it's usually felt as **one beat per bar**, with a little lilt.

Beethoven wrote **Für Elise** in 3/8, and its famous opening is all sixteenth notes. This warm-up gets your fingers ready.

Practise · A 3/8 warm-up

Three eighths in each bar. The sixteenths come in fours, filling two eighths.

5. Für Elise

Beethoven's most famous piano piece: the opening theme.

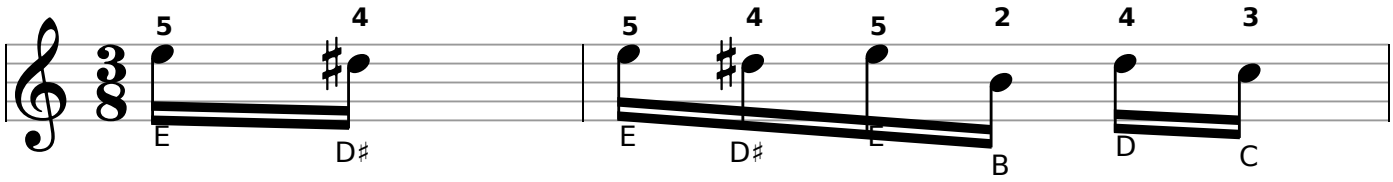
For Elise

Beethoven wrote **Für Elise** around 1810. Nobody is quite sure who Elise was! It's in **A minor** and in **3/8** time: three eighth-note beats per bar.

The famous opening rocks between **E** and **D♯** (the black key just below E). Then the melody falls down to A, and the hands share a rising broken chord.

Practise · The E–D♯ turn

Just the opening: E D♯ E D♯ E B D C, then A. Fingers 5 4 5 4 5 2 4 3, then 1.



Opening example · 3/8 · Am · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Opening theme, right hand

The whole opening theme, right hand. The keyboard shows you where each note is.

Adding the left hand

In the gaps, the left hand plays three quick notes: **A E A** under the A bars and **E E G♯** under the B bar. The right hand then continues the rising line.

Notice how the two hands take turns, like a conversation.

Practise · Für Elise, hands together

Hands take turns. Go slowly and let each note ring.

6. Prelude in C

Bach's flowing broken chords, simplified.

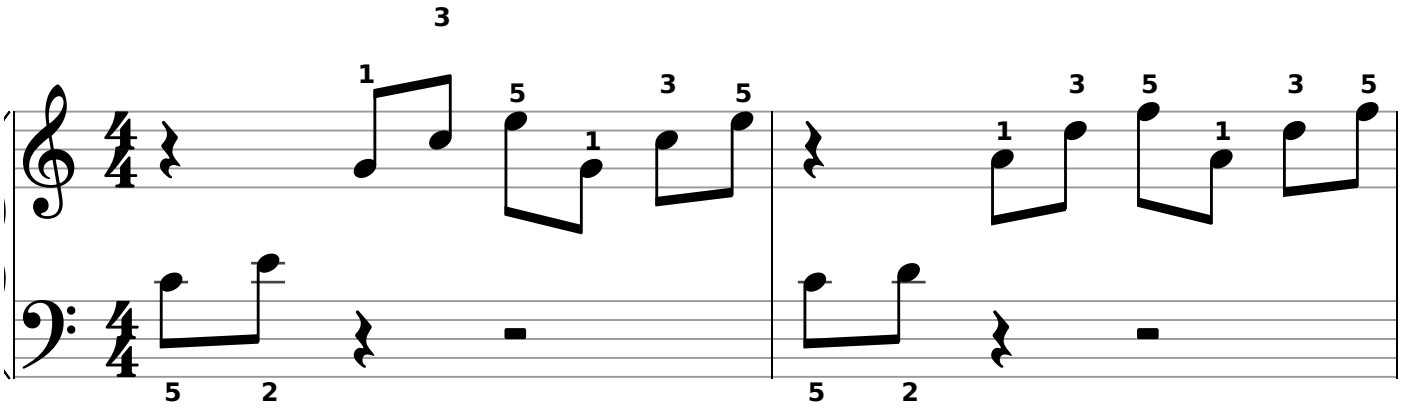
The Well-Tempered Clavier

This prelude opens Bach's **Well-Tempered Clavier** (1722). The whole piece is one pattern: each bar is a chord, broken into flowing notes.

In this simplified version the left hand plays the first two notes of each bar, and the right hand plays the top three notes twice. Let the notes ring into each other.

Practise · Bars 1 to 4

Left hand starts each bar with two notes, then the right hand takes over.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Prelude in C, bars 1 to 8

All eight bars. Smooth and even, like water.

---

7. Pachelbel's Canon

The famous melody over the chords you learned.

Melody meets harmony

You learned the Canon's chords in the Harmony unit. Its most famous line is a slow, falling melody: **E D C B A G A B**, one note per chord.

Here the right hand plays that melody while the left hand plays the roots. Listen to how each melody note fits its chord.

Practise · The melody alone

Slow half notes. Sing it as you play.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Pachelbel's Canon

Hands together. Play it twice: once as written, once even more gently.

8. Schumann: Melody

The first piece in his Album for the Young.

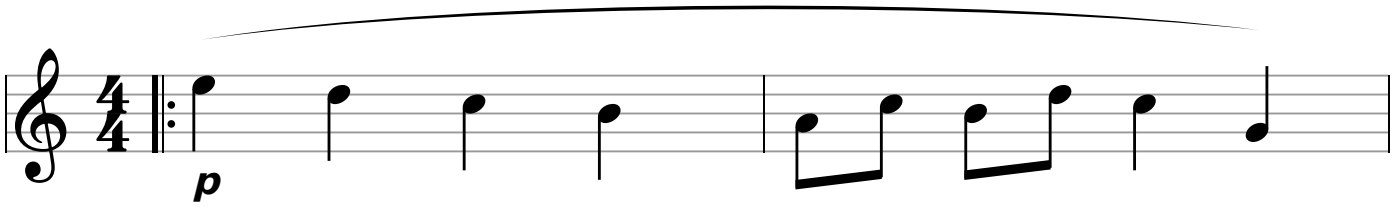
Album for the Young

Robert Schumann wrote his **Album for the Young** (1848) for his daughters to play. "Melody" is the very first piece: a gentle tune over a flowing left hand.

Here you'll play the tune. Keep it **legato** under each slur, and lift gently at the end of each phrase like a singer breathing. The first four bars repeat. The music moves around the keyboard, so choose comfortable fingers and let your hand travel.

Practise · Melody, right hand

Soft and singing. The first line plays twice, then the music climbs and comes home.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

9. Mozart: Minuet in F

Written by Mozart when he was five years old.

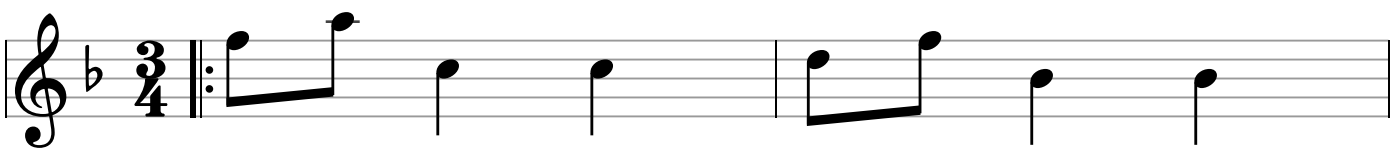
A five-year-old composer

Mozart wrote this **Minuet in F** (K. 2) in 1762, when he was just five. His father wrote it down in his sister Nannerl's music book.

It's in **F major** (B♭ in the key signature) and 3/4. The first half repeats. Each little phrase starts with two quick notes that skip up, then two quarter notes: **short-short long long**. This version keeps Mozart's melody and the lowest note of his bass.

Practise · First half, right hand [F]

Eight bars, played twice. Feel the dance: ONE two three.



Opening example · 3/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Second half, right hand [F]

A darker turn with E♭ and F♯, then the opening returns twice to finish.

Practise · The bass line [F]

Left hand alone. Mostly long notes, with a few walking quarter notes at the cadences.

Practise · Minuet in F, hands together [F]

Both hands, slowly. The app waits for you.

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10. Clementi: Sonatina in C

The bright opening of every piano student's favourite sonatina.

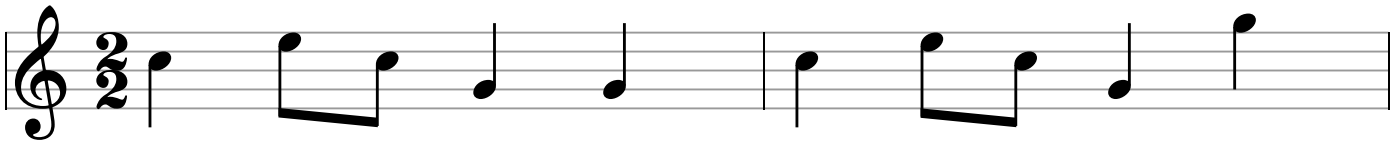
The sonatina

A **sonatina** is a "little sonata". Muzio Clementi's Op. 36 sonatinas (1797) have been played by piano students for over two hundred years, and No. 1 in C is the first of them.

It opens with a cheerful broken chord, answered by quick running notes. It's in **cut time** (2/2): two half-note beats in a bar, so it moves along briskly once you know it. Try it bright and confident, with the running eighths smooth and even.

Practise · Right hand, bars 1 to 8

Start slowly. Bright on the broken chords, smooth on the running eighths.



Opening example · 2/2 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand, bars 1 to 8

The left hand mostly marks the start of each bar. Count the rests.

Practise · Hands together

Both hands, as slowly as you need.

11. The complete Doxology

The whole hymn in G, hands together, with its Amen.

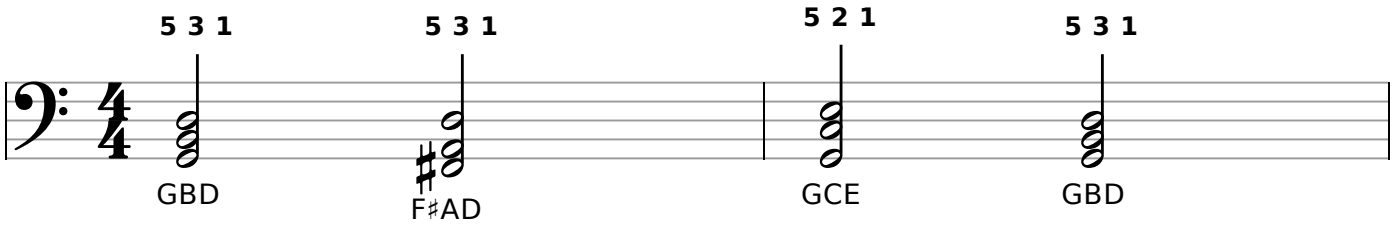
The whole hymn

This is where the Doxology has been heading: the **complete hymn**, in the hymnal key of G major, with both hands, phrasing and dynamics, and the **Amen** at the end.

The left-hand chords are G, C and D, played as inversions so your hand hardly moves. The Amen is the "church" ending: a C chord resolving to G.

Practise · Left hand alone

All four lines of chords and the Amen. Let your hand stay in one place: G stays under finger 5 except for the D chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2, hands together

Melody on top, chords soft underneath.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4, and Amen

Quiet third line, growing into the last. Then a slow, gentle Amen.

Practise · The complete Doxology

The whole hymn, both hands, no keyboard hints. Play it like you're leading a congregation.

12. What comes next

How to keep improving.

You did it

You've gone from finding Middle C to playing Bach, Mozart and Beethoven. That's a real achievement.

Some habits that keep you improving:

- **Little and often.** 15 minutes every day beats two hours on Sunday.
- **Warm up with scales** (C, G and F major, and A minor) before your pieces.
- **Practice slowly.** Speed comes by itself once the notes are secure.
- **Hands separately first**, then together.
- **Replay old lessons.** Try them with the keyboard hints off and the names hidden.

Going further

When you're ready, look for these classic beginner books and pieces. They're all public domain and freely available online:

- Bach: more pieces from the **Anna Magdalena Notebook** (Minuet in G minor, Musette in D)
- Clementi: **Sonatina in C, Op. 36 No. 1**
- Schumann: **Album for the Young** ("Melody", "Soldier's March")
- Burgmüller: **25 Easy Studies, Op. 100**

A teacher, even for a few lessons, is the best way to check your posture and technique. Enjoy the journey!

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13. Joyful, Joyful (grand finale)

The hymn you learned in unit 2, now with a full classical accompaniment.

Your graduation piece

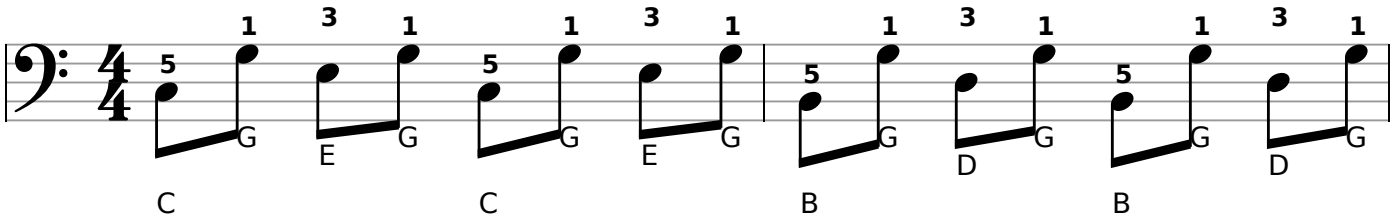
For your final recital, you'll return to **"Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee"**, but played the way a pianist would play it in church or a concert.

- The right hand plays the melody **an octave higher**, so it rings out brightly.
- The left hand plays a flowing **Alberti bass** (bottom, top, middle, top), switching between **C** and **G** chords.

Compare where you started in unit 2 with this. That's how far you've come.

Practise · Left hand alone

The Alberti pattern for the first line: C chord, G chord, C chord, G chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 1, hands together

Right hand starts on the E above the C an octave over Middle C.

Practise · The middle line, hands together

Chords change every two beats here. Go slowly.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, both hands, with hints.

Practise · Your final recital

Your graduation performance. No hints, steady and proud. Enjoy it!

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14. The complete Doxology

The whole hymn in G, both hands, with its Amen.

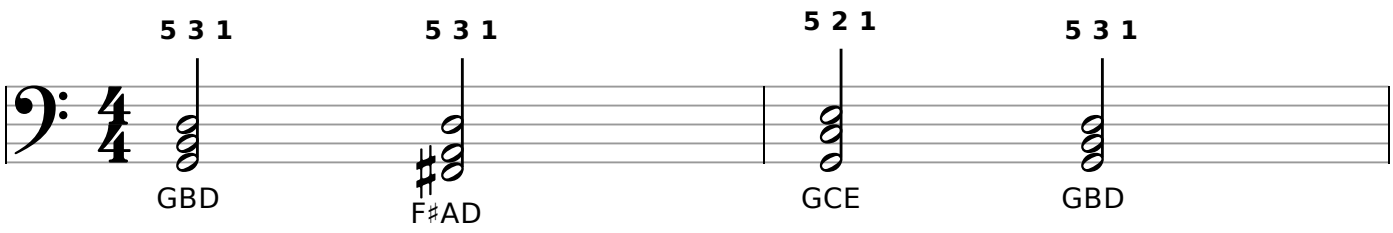
The whole hymn

This is where the Doxology has been heading: the **complete hymn**, in the hymnal key of G major, with both hands, phrasing and dynamics, and the **Amen** at the end.

The left-hand chords are G, C and D, played as inversions so your hand hardly moves. The Amen is the "church" ending: a C chord resolving to G.

Practise · Left hand alone

All four lines of chords and the Amen. Let your hand stay in one place: G stays under finger 5 except for the D chord.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 1 and 2, hands together

Melody on top, chords soft underneath.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4, and Amen

Quiet third line, growing into the last. Then a slow, gentle Amen.

Practise · Your recital

The whole Doxology, both hands, with its Amen. Play it like you're leading a congregation.

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15. Mozart: Sonata in C (opening)

The famous first four bars of Mozart's "easy" sonata, K. 545.

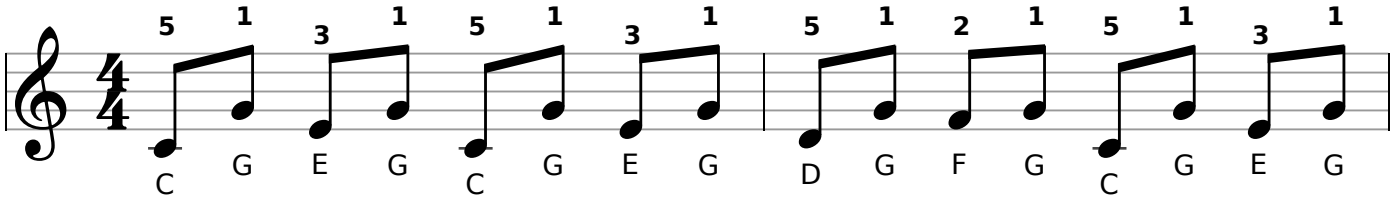
The "easy" sonata

Mozart wrote his **Piano Sonata in C, K. 545** in 1788 "for beginners". It's one of the most famous openings in piano music.

Here are its first four bars. The right hand plays a singing melody, with a quick **sixteenth-note** turn at the end of bars 2 and 4. The left hand plays an **Alberti bass** around Middle C: bottom, top, middle, top.

Practise · Left hand alone

Alberti bass, bottom, top, middle, top. Keep it soft and even.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Right hand alone

Sing the melody. The sixteenths are quick but light.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

Both hands, with hints. Melody on top, left hand quieter.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Read the key, time signature, and patterns before starting a piece.
- ☐ Count sixteenth notes slowly before increasing speed.
- ☐ Practise a difficult passage with separate hands, then together.
- ☐ Perform a chosen piece with steady rhythm, phrasing, and a clear melody, then describe what to improve.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
